

Block

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CRITICAL AND CULTURAL THEORIES

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BLOCK INTRODUCTION: CRITICAL AND CULTURAL THEORIES

This is the Third block of the Course **MDC-006: Media and Communication Theories**. There are four units in this block and each unit addresses major theoretical concepts related by broad Critical and Cultural perspective.

Unit 9: Marxist Theories exposes you to one of the greatest learning traditions of political discourse that changed the political thinking in the world. As a student who wants to pursue a career in academics or journalism, you should have a strong grounding in these classic theories to equip yourself with analytical skills and abilities.

Unit 10: Critical Theories outlines the intellectualism in mass communication impacting political, economic, and socio-cultural sectors. These theories explain the contributions of various schools such as Frankfurt, Glasgow and Chicago Schools of Thoughts to enable you to crystalise your own thoughts on politics and economics and gain new knowledge.

Unit 11: Cultural Studies exposes you to multidisciplinary scholarly roots of mass communication and enables you to understand the ways people produce new culture by using media. It helps you understand and practically apply the studies in the contemporary society and examine the influence of media on culture.

Unit 12: Political Economy Theory is a critical theory that provides you enough knowledge and a forum for the current debates and arguments on political and economic traditions. It enables you to understand events and experiences critically and develops your journalistic skills for understanding political economy of media in India.

It is advisable to study the units in a sequence as each unit is linked to subsequent units through political narrative. It enables you to understand the present political system, ideology and be a critic of social and political movements that are happening around you. This block enhances your capabilities if you choose to work as a journalist and researcher as you understand media ownership and political process of mass communication.

We hope that you will enjoy studying this Block and develop a good understanding of the concepts and perspectives discussed.

UNIT 9 MARXIST THEORY

Structure

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9.0 INTRODUCTION

A host of varied factors have determined civilisation, society and culture as they exist today. Voluminous work has been done on each of them - technology, philosophy, art, polity, economy, discovery and many more, to identify their collective or individual influence on society and culture. Several schools of thoughts or philosophies have risen from research and debates on the variables that have resulted in the social and cultural status quo.

Marxism for example, looks at society and culture from the economic paradigm; that is, economic conditions as influential in determining social, cultural, political dimensions of civilisation. Marxism or Scientific Socialism is the term used for the body of work on the struggle of the working class to achieve a better form of society as theorised by Karl Marx and Friedrich Engels (Rob Sewell and Alan Woods, 2000). It includes the social, economic, political and philosophical

enquiries put forth by the school of thought of Marx and Engels (Andrew Edgar and Peter Sedgwick, 1999).

The writings of Karl Marx were revolutionary- it brought about uprisings, class conflicts and resulted not only in a whole new way of studying society and more importantly culture, but also ushered in a whole new economy and polity.

In this Unit, we shall discuss the arguments put forth by Karl Marx and Friedrich Engels, about Marxist criticism of capitalist societies (their primary target) and understand the plight of the working class in such societies. You may also read the English translation of the *Communist Manifesto*, (1848) drafted by Karl Marx and Friedrich Engels, to have a first-hand understanding of Marxism, economic determinism and Marxist criticism of the capitalist society, symbolised by the bourgeoisie. We shall also try to find answers to the questions such as - How far have Marx's predictions come true? Is Marxism relevant today? Does it apply to the virtual world?

9.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After reading this unit, you should be able to:

- discuss the important elements of the Marxist theory;
- describe the classification of society, social classes and social structures and their relationship to means of production;
- identify the role of media in relation to the Marxist theory; and
- explain how the basic concepts of Marxism are portrayed, borrowed and applied in media text.

9.2 KEY ELEMENTS AND THEIR RELATIONSHIPS

Marxist philosophy and criticism of capitalist society is based on three important concepts: firstly, the economic determinism approach of Marx's analysis of history and society, secondly, the society whose base is economy and the different class structures that this gives rise to, and thirdly, culture, which as a part of the superstructure, is influenced by the base.

9.2.1 Economy

Marxism sees history from the paradigm of successive means of production necessary for existence, that is, from the form of economy that existed. People develop a relationship with each mode of production, and their consciousness is based on this relationship. Therefore, history may be seen as having two dimensions, one, dynamics of the existing means of production and two, a transition to a new mode of production from the existing one (Michael Burawoy, 1978).

Society, according to Marxist theory, is made of the base which refers to the means of production that is, the economy; and the superstructure, which include the other institutions in a society, Marxist criticism of a capitalist economy is aimed at the bourgeoisie, who control the means of production and hence the

working class. Wage-labour is a characteristic of capitalist economies, which is the bare minimum amount that a worker is paid for his labour, just enough for mere existence. Marx criticises wage-labour in capitalist societies where the labourer lives only to increase capital, and this depends on the interest of the bourgeoisie. (*Manifesto*, page 16).

9.2.2 Society

Society refers to “people who interact in a defined territory and share a culture” (Macionis, 2005 p.89). In the Communist Manifesto, Marx and Engels observe that all societies are characterised by social class. Social class in earlier societies were structured as gradations in rank, a complicated arrangement of social orders, different in different times; for example, from the ancient Roman societies to societies in the Middle Ages. Every form of society has seen the exploitation of one class by another. The modern bourgeoisie society came into being after the feudal society, and here also, we see class conflicts or ‘antagonisms’, since this too has resulted in new classes, new forms of oppression and new forms of struggle by the oppressed class.

9.2.3 Culture

Culture is “the values, beliefs, behaviour; and material objects that together form a people’s way of life” (Macionis, 2005, p.59). It may be Non-material, referring to ideas/symbols/language/values or it may be Material, referring to tangible, things created by people; artifacts and technologies. Culture is continuous, it is a way of life passed on by and to generations.

According to Marxism, the economic structure is the real basis on which the institutions in the superstructure (i.e., cultural institutions) arise- be it political, legal, educational, artistic or any other.

Check Your Progress 1

Notes: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those ones given at the end of this Unit.

1) Briefly explain the key concepts of Marxism.

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2) What is meant by wage labour?

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3) What is Material and Non-material culture?

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9.3 CRITICAL AND CULTURAL STUDIES

You may ask why are such economic and social class theories important in mass communication? Marxist interpretations, though varied, agree that the media are used as tools by and for those in power thus necessitating their study. This was argued in *German Ideology*, a collection of manuscripts written by Marx and Engels in 1846, but published only in 1932 (www.marxists.org). Later Marxist theorists in the twentieth century highlighted the ideological effects of the media in support of ruling class interests (Denis McQuail, 2010).

Cultural studies are microscopic and interpretive, with a focus on the use of media to influence or shape culture that are practiced as part of our daily lives. Political Economy theories are macroscopic structural theories with a focus on the control over media by elites who use it to maintain their social, political, and economic dominance. Critical theories stand for certain values and these values are used as the base in their evaluation and critique of the status quo. They also suggest alternative ways to interpret the role of mass media in society. Mass media and mass culture is the focus of Critical theory.

9.3.1 Marxism

Born in 1818 in Germany, Karl Marx is best known for *The Communist Manifesto* (1848) which he co-authored with Friedrich Engels (born in 1820), *A Contribution to the Critique of Political Economy* (1859), and *Capital—A Critique of Political Economy* Volume I (1867). Volume II and III of *Capital* were edited and published by Engels after the death of Marx.

Capital, famously known as *Das Kapital*, deals with the theory of capitalist system as propounded by Marx and is considered the ‘Bible of the working class’ (Encyclopaedia Britannica).

The writings of Karl Marx constitute some of the most widely accepted ideas in Europe after the Mass Society Theory, forming the foundation for much of European social theory and research after World War II (Baran and Davis, 2000).

Marxism is both a theory of society and a political movement based on the idea that social history is full of class struggles (Brian L. Ott and Robert L. Mack, 2014). The capitalist (bourgeoisie) who controlled the means of modern production (the base) and exploited the working class (the proletariat), was the target of Marxist criticism. This class system was according to Marx, the cause of all social problems, and he called for a revolution of the Proletariats to end this inequality.

Neo Marxists, who were mainly from the school of British cultural studies, focused on the superstructure, on ideology and culture rather than on the base, the means of production or the economy (Baran and Davis, 2000).

9.3.2 Ideology

The French philosopher Destutt de Tracy first used the term at the end of the eighteenth century to mean ‘a science (logos) of ideas’ (Andrew Edgar and Peter Sedgwick, eds, 1999, p. 189). It was Marx who made it an important concept in critical studies. Oxford dictionary defines it as “a system of ideas and ideals,

especially one which forms the basis of economic or political theory and policy”. Marx refers to ideology as the ideas of those who control material production and political system. According to Marx, the ideas of the ruling class are the ruling ideas: “The ruling ideas of each age have ever been the ideas of its ruling class” (*Manifesto*, p.21). This propaganda is possible because the bourgeoisie control modes of communication and education like the school, church and mass media. (Andrew Edgar and Peter Sedgwick, eds, 1999)

9.3.3 Hegemony

Derived from the Greek word *hegemon*, hegemony in common parlance refers to the rule or influence of one country over other countries (Andrew Edgar and Peter Sedgwick, eds, 1999). McQuail (2010) defines it as a kind of dominant understanding that works discreetly, without open coercion. Hegemony, first introduced by Antonio Gramsci, the twentieth century Marxist theorist, was described by him as the presentation of ideas of the dominant class in contemporary capitalism through mass media, the church, family and school. Hegemony is the power that comes out of the above institutions, especially the media, to support the power status quo and also to exclude opposing, competing values (Denis McQuail, 2010).

9.3.4 Political Economy of Media

This theory focuses on the relationship between the economic structure of a society and the media industry, including ideological content of media. The media institution is not just part of the economic system, it is also closely linked to the political system. The media therefore are influenced or are used by economic and political vested interests. Reduction of independent media sources, media monopolies, lack of risk taking, lack of interest or investment in less profitable media functions/ or media (closing of the newspaper industry in the US, lack of investment in documentary film making, for example), neglect of smaller and poorer sections of the audience, lack of objectivity in news reporting especially that of politics and governance, lack of diversity and plurality in media content are characteristics of media industry controlled by economic and political compulsions. Media content is therefore commodified (McQuail, 2010).

McQuail (2010, p. 97) suggests that the Political Economy theory is growing in relevance today, due to several trends in media industry and technology, and to some extent, due to the reduced importance of Marxist analysis. He identifies the trends as growth in global media concentration, growing information economy, and decreasing government control over broadcasting and telecommunication due to convergence, but growing digital divide.

9.3.5 Frankfurt School

The Frankfurt School refers to the philosophy/Marxist approach of the members and associates of the Frankfurt Institute for Social Research (1920), the most famous of them being Max Horkheimer (who became its Director in 1930), Theodor Adorno and Jurgen Habermas. The Critical Theory approach was used by the Frankfurt School, meaning that it was not just an analysis of social conditioning of knowledge, but also identification of the various structures of power intrinsic to the conditioning. This conditioning of knowledge is seen as important in reproducing a society that was politically unequal and divided by

class. The Frankfurt School also applied psychoanalysis, thereby combining the work of Marx and Freud.

The Frankfurt School is famous for its contribution as theorists of culture. Horkheimer and Adorno tried to link Marxist sociology of art with conventional aesthetics. They considered art, especially avant-garde art that was associated with high culture, as an expression of resistance to the capitalist status quo. This was against mass culture as it was a product of mass media. According to Andrew Edgar and Peter Sedgwick (1999), both, however, had to acknowledge that popular culture and popular art was more superior to high art, in terms of acceptance and understanding by a majority of the people.

Check Your Progress 2

Notes: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those ones given at the end of this Unit.

Briefly explain the following terms:

- 1) Ideology.....
- 2) Hegemony
- 3) Political Economy

9.4 MARXIST THEORY: CORE CONCEPTS

By now you would be familiar with the fundamental ideas and concepts of Marxist Theory. We will explore them in some more detail in this section of the Unit. Understanding the concepts is crucial for you as students of communication, you may be in the field of content production and dissemination. These concepts form the basis in analysing media text from the Marxist point of view, be it news or entertainment content.

9.4.1 Materialism

According to Marx, social existence depends on the kind of relationship men have (albeit without a choice) with their material means of production. The economic structure of the society is the base on which legal and political superstructure arises. Social consciousness of existence is an outcome of these processes. As Marx observes, “The mode of production of material life conditions the social, political and intellectual life-process in general. It is not the consciousness of men that determines their being, but on the contrary it is their social being that determines their consciousness” (Marx, 1857-58, p. 3).

Materialism is important for a new social order to arise or for the present social order to continue. A new social order can arise only when all productive forces in the present are sufficiently developed. According to Marx, the change in the economic base transforms the whole superstructure more slowly or more rapidly.

9.4.2 Base and Superstructure

We have already noted the Marxist definition of a society as consisting of base and superstructure. Base refers to the means of production or economic institutions and these are ruled by the bourgeoisie. The superstructure refers to the cultural, political, educational and other institutions. Marxist debates focus on the extent

to which the economic base determines the superstructure. Marxism understands social structures as being formed based on the exploitation of the subordinate class. Marxism is not just seen as an economic philosophy. Politically it stands for a community where the working class are liberated, resulting in a non-exploitative society. Though Marx has not tackled culture (the superstructure) directly, Marxists approach culture as part of the class struggle. (Andrew Edgar and Peter Sedgwick, eds, (1999).

9.4.3 Bourgeoisie and Proletariat

Engels in the 1888 edition of the *Manifesto* defines the bourgeoisie and the proletariat. By bourgeoisie is meant the class of modern capitalists, owners of the means of social production and employers of wage labour. By proletariat, the class of modern wage labourers who, having no means of production of their own, are reduced to selling their labour power in order to live [Engels, 1888 English edition].

In their ground-breaking *Communist Manifesto* (1848), Marx and Engels state that society in the modern ‘epoch’ is more and more a divide between the two directly opposing classes— bourgeoisie and proletariat. This clear division meant that conflict was inevitable, the bourgeoisie trying to maintain the status quo and the proletariat fighting against the domination. The bourgeoisie are themselves a product of the technological and economic advances made possible by the modern industry. As industry developed, there was a corresponding political advancement of the bourgeoisie. Marx and Engels made a scathing attack on the bourgeoisie for eliminating everything that was held in regard by the earlier societies:

“The bourgeoisie ... has converted the physician, the lawyer, the priest, the poet, the man of science, into its paid wage labourers. The bourgeoisie has torn away from the family its sentimental veil, and has reduced the family relation to a mere money relation.” (*Communist Manifesto*, 1848, pp 4, 5)

Unlike in the earlier societies, the bourgeoisie are constantly revolutionising the tools of production, thus creating conditions of continuous change of relations to production and to the relations of the society. The continuous modifications in production, and therefore disturbance of social environments, ceaseless uncertainty and agitation are the characteristics of the modern bourgeoisie epoch, claim Marx and Engels. Nothing is constant and everything become obsolete even before they become standard and the bourgeoisie is therefore faced with the need of a constantly expanding market to sell its products across the globe.

Raw materials are got from all over the world, and their products are sold everywhere. This has resulted in an erosion of old wants which is replaced by a demand for new products of distant countries. Self-sufficiency has made way to global interdependence of nations.

Activity -1

Do you agree with Marx and Engels’s criticism of this need for constant change in production as upsetting social and national equations? Discuss with the help of an example.

Along with other products, intellectual creations become common property of the world, and national biases are more and more impossible. What Marx and Engels criticise is that, according to them, “It compels all nations, on pain of extinction, to adopt the bourgeois mode of production; it compels them to introduce what it calls civilisation into their midst, i.e., to become bourgeois themselves. In one word, it creates a world after its own image”. (ibid.p 6)

The conflict between the bourgeoisie and the proletariat is the basis for many a literature and cinema, and this account must seem familiar to you as a reader. This has resulted in the application of the main concepts in Marxism and ideological criticism to deconstruct media text, both fact and fiction, to a large extent. We shall deal with this later in this unit.

Marx and Engels further outlined the inevitable progress of the proletariat. Conflicts of other kinds also helped the proletariat to develop. The bourgeoisie had to fight those members of the aristocracy who were against the progress of the industry and they had to compete with bourgeoisie of other countries. It was obliged therefore, to seek the support of proletariat, for political reasons. Hence, they supplied them with education and other support. There were also some from the ruling class and bourgeoisie ideologists, who supported the proletariat in times of decisive struggles.

The lower middle class, made of small tradesman and peasants, was absorbed into the proletariat class by the bourgeoisie. The number of proletariat class grew with the growing number of industries. As they grew in number and were more and more concentrated, their demands grew and they formed trade unions, they were further helped by growth in communication and railways. Marx and Engels opined that while the proletariat’s conflict with the bourgeoisie was revolutionary, the opposition of the lower middle-class small tradesman and peasantry was more conservative in nature, in fact reactionary, since they fought to go back to the old times.

These classes disappear and disintegrate, while according to Marx and Engels, the proletariat is its “special and essential product.”(p. 12). The *Communist Manifesto* also predicts the fall of the bourgeoisie. The proletariat are large in numbers, and therefore, unlike earlier movements that were of the minorities, their movement is by an ‘immense majority’, and in the interest of the ‘immense majority’ (Marx And Engels, 1848).

9.4.4 Alienation

The concept of alienation or isolation is predominant in Marxist criticism of a capitalist society. The bourgeoisie is separated from the proletariat, the proletariat from each other, from their families, children and their work. As the bourgeoisie grew and created more and more capital, so did the proletarians, who wielded the machines and worked in large factories like modern day robots. Their relevance in society depended on the capital they produced and were therefore reduced to the status of commodities themselves. Extensive use of machinery and division of labour resulted in monotony, loss of individuality and a lack of pride in one’s own work. Proletariats are not only slaves of the bourgeoisie and the bourgeois State, they are ultimately slaves to the machines, the overseers and the factories where they work.

Activity- 2

Watch the movie *Modern Times* by Charlie Chaplin, who in his inimitable style has told the story of the poor proletariat in a capitalist society, to more fully understand what Marx and Engels meant.

9.4.5 The Consumer Society

The media play an important role by providing distractions and momentary gratifications. Advertising stimulates desire to possess commodities which helps temporarily to escape alienation, and this in turn makes people work harder and thereby falling into a vicious cycle. The more the people worked, the more they felt alienated. This feeling of alienation drives people into impulsive consumption. In this, the capitalist is ably assisted by advertising, indeed, s/he uses it as a tool to drive people to consume products and maintain the consumer culture by creating a consumer society so that the economic status quo continues.

German Marxist Wolfgang Fritz Haug argues that the advertising industry (who he calls the servant of capital interests) not just creates a consumer society, but moulds and exploits human sexuality in order to alter human needs and instincts. Advertising has resulted in 'consumer fetish' or consumer lust.

9.4.6 False Consciousness

We have already seen how Marx considers the ideas of a given period are the ideas of those in power. It goes without saying that these ideas are therefore, expected to be ideas that are put forth to serve their own interests. It can also be assumed then, that the ideas people have are the ideas that the ruling class wants them to have. Here again, the media is used as a tool, used to spread false consciousness about the status quo. The media are criticised of 'clouding the minds' of people with ruling class ideas. According to Berger (1991), the bourgeoisie create false understanding of class by making proletariat believe that the social structures are natural, and therefore be accepted as inevitable. They propagate the notion of the self-made man, and in capitalist societies like America, there is the myth of the classless society – but class does exist.

Check Your Progress 3

Notes: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those ones given at the end of this Unit.

1) What is Marx's idea of materialism?

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2) Explain the class conflict as portrayed by Marx.

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3) What does the term 'consumer society' mean?

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9.5 MARXIST THEORY AND MEDIA

Marx and Engels contend that the class that owns the means of material production also controls the means of mental production, the latter, which include the media. Media messages disseminated by those who control the economy are planned in such a way as to confirm the legitimate existence and values of the class society. Given the powerful role played by media as an institution, it is imperative that they are subject to critical analysis and evaluation.

9.5.1 Critical Media Studies

Some common parameters are used by sociologists, economists, political scientists, literary researchers and others for studying media: *firstly*, the critical scholar views the media with an attitude of skepticism in the study of how media work and what they do. *Secondly*, the approach to critical media studies is humanistic. This is interpretive and therefore has a subjective element, with its basis on certain intellectual concerns and approaches like freedom, responsibility, intellectual for social welfare. *Thirdly*, critical media studies approach media in terms of the political and practical implications of the findings of their research on media, rather than just reporting it, making this approach judgmental. *Fourthly*, critical media studies is done with the hope to bring about social justice and betterment with the use of the powerful media. Media are expected to be not just responsible, but also accountable.

9.5.2 Marxist Analysis of Media Industry

Marxist analysis of the media industry involves analysing the various characteristics of media as an industry in a capitalist economy or even in a democratic polity: studying patterns of media ownership, market share, concentration, media conglomerates, global media houses, integration, vertical and horizontal, also cross media ownership. Other aspects of analysis include strategies to maximise profit, which could be many, to attract more consumers and therefore, more advertising revenue. Planned obsolescence is an interesting concept where a product is built to make it obsolete so that consumers turn towards a new product. Even otherwise, obsolescence has challenged media houses to cross over to newer media, for example, while most newspapers closed in the US, a lot of them converted themselves into online newspapers. Large newspapers produced their online counterparts, with an eye on the trend of increasing online newspaper readership.

The concept of logic and safety, according to Ott and Mack (2014) is also an important aspect of profit maximisation- media houses 'play safe'- they repeat successful formula and avoid expensive experiments. This has resulted in a woeful

lack of newer and fresher programme content. Another strategy is to cover celebrities and to have reality shows involving celebrities to get more eyeballs, and thereby increase TRPs on television or increase viewer footfalls on the Internet. Media is subject to heavy criticism by Marxist critics (Ott and Mack, 2014); as media is seen today as profit oriented with very little sense of responsibility, there is no diversity in content, and less plurality of views on the media.

9.5.4 Marxist Analysis of Media Text

An analysis of the media industry is incomplete without the analysis of media text or content. The core concepts of Marxist theory are applied to analysis of media text – be it in the form of news where one can study the editorial policy of a newspaper, for example, doing a content analysis of newspapers with Marxist concepts as the basis for analysis, or in the form of entertainment. Application of the Marxist concepts of upper-class exploitation, miseries of the working class, alienation, consumer fetish, false consciousness etc., can be seen as the theme in most serious and even commercial cinema. Heroes inspire revolutions and conflicts and they mostly come from the working class. The villain is almost always the capitalist or the owner of the business or in the rural milieu, the ubiquitous landlord who dominates agricultural production. These fictional representations use various symbolisms direct and indirect to tell the story of the capitalist society as Marx saw it. Indian cinema includes the additional dimension of caste which has divided society into several unequal structures. Can you recall a few movies that you have seen that has Marxist philosophy as its theme?

Check Your Progress 4

Notes: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those ones given at the end of this Unit.

1) What are critical media studies?

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2) Write a note on Marxist analysis of media text.

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Activity-3

Undertake a critical analysis of the news stories telecast in a news channel of your choice. Keep the Marxist criticism of media as the basis.

9.6 LET US SUM UP

In this unit you were exposed to Marxist theory as theorised by Karl Marx and Engels. You would have seen that Karl Marx is without doubt one of the greatest philosophers of all time. His arguments have been interpreted across the globe and have given rise to new approaches to his theory of social class and criticism of the modern capitalist society. Even if it is argued that Communism as a polity is near extinct, we cannot ignore the fact that Marx's predictions of social exploitation continue in societies across the world, in some form or the other. Socialism, as a political commitment has been adopted in countries like India, where the attempt is to find a balance between the industrial and economic 'progress' of capitalist countries and the communist/Marxist fight for social justice. Classless society, though, sadly remains a Marxist dream.

9.7 FURTHER READINGS

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9.8 KEY TERMS

Alienation: The concept of alienation or isolation is predominant in Marxist criticism of a capitalist society. The bourgeoisie is separated from the proletariat, the proletariat from each other, from their families, their children, their work.

Base and Superstructure: Marx defines a society as being made up of the base and superstructure. Base refers to the means of production or economic institutions and these are ruled by the bourgeoisie. The superstructure refers to the cultural, political, educational and other institutions.

Bourgeoisie and Proletariat: By bourgeoisie is meant the class of modern capitalists, owners of the means of social production and employers of wage labour. By proletariat, the class of modern wage labourers who, having no means of production of their own, are reduced to selling their labour power in order to live. (Engels, 1888 English edition)

Consumer society: The capitalist uses advertising as a tool to drive people to consume products and maintain the consumer culture by creating a consumer society for the economic status quo to continue.

Culture: is “the values, beliefs, behaviour; and material objects that together form a people’s way of life” (Macionis, 2005, pg.59).

Cultural studies: are microscopic and interpretive, with a focus on the use of media to influence or shape culture that are practiced as part of our daily lives.

Critical theories: are macroscopic, structural theories with a focus on the control over media by elites who use it to maintain their social, political and economic dominance.

Critical media studies: Given the powerful role played by media as an institution, they are subject to critical analysis and evaluation.

Economy: Marxism refers to economy as the means of production necessary for existence that forms the base of a capitalist society.

False Consciousness: The media is used in capitalist society as a tool to spread false consciousness about the status quo. The media are criticised of ‘clouding the minds’ of people with ruling class ideas of a classless society and the notion of the self-made man.

Frankfurt School: refers to the philosophy/Marxist approach of a social theory and a critical theory.

Marxism or Scientific Socialism: is the term used for the body of work on the struggle of the working class to achieve a better form of society as theorised by Karl Marx and Friedrich Engels.

Materialism: According to Marx, social existence depends on the kind of relationship men have (albeit without a choice) with their material means of production. The mode of production of material life conditions the social, political and intellectual life-process in general.

Society: Society refers to “people who interact in a defined territory and share a culture” (Macionis, 2005 pg.89). In the *Communist Manifesto*, Marx and Engels observe that all societies are characterised by social class.

9.9 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

- 1) Marxism or Scientific Socialism is the term used for the body of work on the struggle of the working class to achieve a better form of society as theorised by Karl Marx and Friedrich Engels. It includes the social, economic, political and philosophical enquiries put forth by the school of thought of Marx and Engels.
- 2) Wage-labour is a characteristic of capitalist economies, which is the bare minimum amount that a worker is paid for his labour, just enough for mere existence.
- 3) Culture is continuous, it is a way of life passed on by and to generations. It may be Nonmaterial – referring to ideas/symbols/language/values or it may

be Material - referring to things that are tangible, made of things created by people; artifacts and technologies.

Check Your Progress 2

- 1) **Ideology:** The French philosopher Destutt de Tracy first used the term 'Ideology' to mean 'a science (logos) of ideas'. Marx refers to ideology as the ideology of those who control material production and political system and in any society, the ideas of the ruling class are the ruling ideas.
- 2) **Hegemony:** was described by Antonio Gramsci, the twentieth century Marxist theorist, as the presentation of ideas of the dominant class in contemporary capitalism through mass media, the church, family and school. Hegemony is the power that comes out of the institutions, especially the media, to support the power status quo and also to exclude opposing, competing values.
- 3) **Political Economy:** focuses on the relationship between the economic structure of a society and the media industry, including ideological content of media. The media institution is not just part of the economic system, it is also closely linked to the political system. The media therefore are influenced by or are used by economic and political vested interests.

Check Your Progress 3

- 1) According to Marx, social existence depends on the kind of relationship men have (albeit without a choice) with their material means of production. Materialism is important for a new social order to arise or for the present social order to continue. A new social order can arise only when all productive forces in the present have been sufficiently developed.
- 2) Marx and Engels argue that society in the modern 'epoch' is more and more a divide between the two directly opposing classes - the bourgeoisie and the proletariat. This clear division meant that conflict was inevitable – the bourgeoisie trying to maintain the status quo and the proletariat fighting against the domination.
- 3) Advertising stimulates desire to possess commodities which help temporarily to escape alienation, and this in turn makes people work harder, thereby falling into a vicious cycle. The capitalist uses advertising as a tool to drive people to consume products and maintain the consumer culture by creating a consumer society for the economic status quo to continue.

Check Your Progress 4

- 1) Critical media studies question the status quo and offer ways to interpret the role of mass media. Given the powerful role played by media as an institution, it is imperative that they are subject to critical analysis and evaluation. A host of different theoretical perspectives- sociological, economic, political, literary, are used to study media.
- 2) An analysis of the media industry is incomplete without the analysis of media text or content. The core concepts of Marxist theory are applied to the analysis of media text- be it in the form of news, or in the form of entertainment.

UNIT 10 CRITICAL THEORIES

Structure

- 10.0 Introduction
- 10.1 Learning Outcomes
- 10.2 Critical Theory
 - 10.2.1 Cultural Imperialism
 - 10.2.2 Enlightenment
- 10.3 Frankfurt School
 - 10.3.1 Audience
 - 10.3.2 Self-deception
- 10.4 Digital Media Theory
 - 10.4.1 Interactivity, Automation and Personalisation
 - 10.4.2 Convergence
- 10.5 Social Networking Theory
 - 10.5.1 Empowerment
 - 10.5.2 Issues with Social Networking
- 10.6 Glasgow School of Thought
- 10.7 Chicago School of Thought
 - 10.7.1 Interactionism
 - 10.7.2 Performance
- 10.8 Let Us Sum Up
- 10.9 Further Readings
- 10.10 Check You Progress: Possible Answers

10.0 INTRODUCTION

We have discussed in the previous units that theoretical framework is a significant part of any research. Theories produce knowledge and furtherance of knowledge is needed to enlarge the vision of the society. The discipline of Mass Communication has grown rapidly and has contributed immensely to the creation of knowledge and information.

The role of mass media in human society is subjected to scrutiny from different quarters because mass media are believed to have significant influence on society. Mass media has impact on political, economic, social, and cultural sectors. People by and large depend on mass media for news and information. You have read in the previous units that since the beginning of the twentieth century, media theories have become crystallised with public and academic debates and discussions. From magic bullet to limited effects theory, the mass of knowledge that has emanated is quite discerning. Scholars across the world, especially in Europe and the United States have made seminal contribution through various theories to the understanding of media ecology and performance. Their assessment has enriched the discipline no end. The universities like Glasgow, Birmingham, Toronto, Chicago, and Frankfurt Institute of Social Sciences have been in the forefront to critically dissect the structure, role, and performance of mass media. In this unit, we shall discuss these critical theories of mass communication.

10.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After a thorough study of the present unit, you should be able to:

- discuss the importance of critical theories of mass communication;
- examine the postulations of Frankfurt School scholars;
- analyse the finer aspects of digital media theory;
- debate on the social networking theory;
- evaluate the contribution of Glasgow Media Group; and
- analyse the theoretical output of Chicago School of thought.
- apply some of these theories in your work.

10.2 CRITICAL THEORY

A critical theory questions the status quo and offers alternate ways to interpret the social role of mass media. The critical theory advocates social change. Most critical theorists believe that mass media support and sustain status quo. The critical theories produce complex explanations for media support to status quo.

Critical theory evaluates specific social institutions and focuses on mass media and mass culture promoted by these institutions. Critical theorists link mass media mass culture to various social issues. Even if they do not find mass media as the source of identified problems, critical theorists question media for aggravating the problems or preventing problems from being identified and solving them. Theorists strongly believe that media content production takes place in a restricted environment and criticise mass media for advocating status quo.

Reports of social movements mean problems with the status quo. Movements are launched because social problems are not properly addressed as they demand change in the existing social structure. Media persons are positioned between the two confronting sides. Leaders of social movements seek coverage and hit the street for public attention to their issues. On the other hand, power elites want the movement coverage to be limited or blocked. “Spin doctoring” is the term used here. Research has shown that the mainstream media mostly highlight the darker side of such movements to denigrate them. They deliberately ignore the issues and lack commitment.

The Critical theory acts as a critique of political system, society and economic notions and calls for changes in the existing world and keeps on asking vital questions regarding media ownership, control and performance. On the flip side, we can say that it is too much political and subjective, does not have scientific validation of its research methods.

We must note that the label critical theory was the contribution of German philosopher Max Horkheimer who published an essay titled ‘Critical and traditional theory’ in 1937. He promoted this approach to study the society and its culture at the Institute for Social Research in Frankfurt. Many other scholars joined the Frankfurt Institute, which was later identified, as Frankfurt School.

10.2.1 Cultural Imperialism

Cultural imperialism is also labelled as a critical theory. It is like other theories propounded by the Frankfurt School of neo-Marxists. According to Littlejohn (1991 p15), it contains “a loose confederation of ideas held together by a common interest in the quality of communication and human life.”

Cultural imperialism refers to unequal distribution of media content with western values dominating to influence media audience in non-western societies. Media content flow from the west was criticised for subverting local, indigenous, and heterogeneous culture in pluralistic society by invading ‘cultural space’ of people. This theory is highly critical of promoting westernisation by invading culture through mass media content to promote capitalist economy.

It is said that the critical theories operate at the macro level and concentrate on broader issues pertaining to transnational media, cultural flow, and political economy. Any study of cultural imperialism is long drawn, with focus on media audience.

10.2.2 Enlightenment

Enlightenment is a movement that stressed on rational thought. Dialectic of Enlightenment is a seminal work of Frankfurt School of Critical Theory. The Frankfurt School’s work is based on the core philosophy of enlightenment as against hereditary privileges, religious dogma and tyrannical rulers and governments. It advocated a free society with critical reasoning. This theory was developed post First World War which focuses on ‘culture industry’ where media is a partner in creating more myths and distortions to benefit power elites.

In 1930s, the Frankfurt School believed that rationality was used to promote technologies and administrative paradigms essentially to dominate and control the society, rather than liberating it. Both Max Horkheimer and Theodor W. Adorno of Frankfurt School wanted to promote a critical theory to keep up the promise of freedom alive, against the supremacy of instrumental reason. The Marxian criticism of capitalism became the core principle of such a move. It opposed commodification of mass media and exposed how capitalism through its hidden operations would work against the enlightenment principles of liberty, equality, and fraternity, and find ways to remove the blocks.

The critical theory sought a complete evaluation of the power systems in existence and its own assumptions for a continuous scrutiny. Frankfurt School argued that, culture was fundamental to all social developments in the world. However, the subsequent developments in Europe led to the emergence of totalitarian states, and the move towards state capitalism. Friedrich Pollock of Frankfurt School observed that it was happening even in the market driven United States. Mass production and consumption were manipulated to suit the State’s economic policies and initiatives.

Adorno was not merely interested in the ideological role of media within the realm of politics, but also in the power relations within the framework of popular culture. Both Horkheimer and Adorno were critical of standardisation of popular culture. They lamented the absence of high culture due to factory type production of art and culture to make profits. It was the beginning of suspecting the

discriminatory abilities of the audience, as they were industry's productions. Adorno called the media audience as 'amphibians' that moved between distrust and pleasures of immersion in the warm waters of routine and repetition. The main theme of critical theory is that culture is the place of social struggle.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answer

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit

1) What are the characteristics of critical theory?

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2) What areas come under the label of critical theories?

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3) What were the ideas of Max Horkheimer and Theodor Adorno on mass media?

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10.3 FRANKFURT SCHOOL

Frankfurt School known for neo-Marxist theory, became popular during 1920 and 1930s. It was based at the University of Frankfurt in Germany. Two scholars who headed the school whose contribution to the theoretical knowledge of media communication is immense are Theodor Adorno and Max Horkheimer. The Frankfurt School integrated Marxist critical theory with Hermeneutic Theory, different from the later types of neo-Marxist theories. Most scholars of the Frankfurt School were trained in disciplines of humanities, but were attracted to Marxism. They used Marxism to critically analyse the society and its culture. Their writings supported different forms of high culture like 'symphony, music, great literature, and art'. They believed that, high culture had its own integrity and value but the power elites should not abuse them to gain more power.

Frankfurt School writings should be analysed in their political content as they took 'the people's needs, interest, and striving towards autonomy....' into consideration. The Frankfurt School reminds us of the criticisms by conservative humanistic writers. While the latter focused on specific media contents, Adorno and Horkheimer analysed the larger content producing industries. It is observed that Frankfurt School had a great influence on the US social science research because of the migration of those scholars to the US due to the persecution by

Nazis, especially of the Jewish scholars. Nazis substituted high culture with their own folk culture.

The European research in particular derived ideas from the Frankfurt School. It supported the movements for social change and defended public service media systems. This led to the combining of communication with neo-Marxist and institutional traditions of theories. It has recorded the integration of communication institutions with focus on business and state policy authorities in an expansive capitalist economy. It has also documented the resistance and protests of the working class, rather subaltern class and movements that opposed the state policies and practices of supporting the ideas of liberalisation, commercialisation and privatisation. The cultural imperialism theory is also inspired by the thoughts of Frankfurt School.

10.3.1 Audience

If we revert to the early years of media theory formulation we can understand that the communication process was described with an emphasis on production and transmission of messages. A few scholars have considered this as an over-emphasis on message design logics and in the process excluded the theorisation of the meaning and the agency in the process of message reception. One of the earliest approaches to the study of mass media originated at the Frankfurt School by Max Horkheimer and Theodor Adorno. Their essay, 'The Culture Industry: Enlightenment as Mass Deception' was published in 1944 in which the authors described mass media industry as a culture industry. The essay made a critical assessment of the receiving public as a victim of crooked culture industry. For Horkheimer and Adorno, audiences themselves are responsible for their own deception because they participate in it. The critics provided a bleak picture of the function of mass media. The culture industry, according to these authors, has a mesmerising effect on an innocent audience. The public is converted into subordination; Adorno and Horkheimer offer a caution as to the seductive appeal of entertainment industry. Adorno also described the audience not as a subject, 'but an object of calculation'.

10.3.2 Self-deception

In other words, media consumers are pawns in their own deception, by being participants. Horkheimer and Adorno took their presentation from the notion that the concept of freedom was central to the modern and contemporary political philosophy. The Frankfurt School produced the construct of cultural industries and their draconian impact on people's thinking abilities. We have to remember here that in the early years of the twentieth century, the field of popular communication gained more public attention.

The mass culture critique was advocated by the German intellectuals who migrated to the other countries. Horkheimer and Adorno opined that culture industry endlessly produced 'identical forms of entertainment' that made masses to opt for 'mindless consumerism'. The Frankfurt School endorsed the opposition of elitists to popular culture types.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) What the Frankfurt School was known for?

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2) Why were mass media equated with culture industry?

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3) Explain the difference between mass culture and class culture.

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10.4 DIGITAL MEDIA THEORY

The digital technology is a twentieth century phenomenon. The information society concept is the contribution of digital technology. The digital media theory identifies the four major functions of digital media: they are: Interactivity, Automation, Personalisation, and Convergence. Let us look at them in detail.

10.4.1 Interactivity, Automation and Personalisation

Interactivity is a major characteristic of digital media. John Pavlik et al have identified features of interactivity: “It is a dialogue that occurs between a human and a computer programme (this includes e-mails, online chats and discussion group, as at either end of the communication flow – it is a human interacting with a computer programme, with the internet simply the channel).

Computers are automated to perform many complex functions. Automation has changed the very face of journalism. It has made the job of media persons easy. Besides, it has made media use public thus the user is no longer anonymous.

Automation has led to personalisation of media. Users can seek specific type of information or news depending upon geography, interest or identified topics. However, quality of digital information has its own effects on media houses, audience, and the society as a whole. The timeline factor of conventional media has totally disappeared in the digital world.

10.4.2 Convergence

The integration of computing, telecommunications, and media in a digital environment is referred as convergence. Different media like print, audio and

video have merged to become one digital media. The effects of transformation due to convergence of technologies on mass communication can be seen in four principal sectors:

- 1) The communication content
- 2) The relationship between media and their consumers
- 3) The structure of media organisations
- 4) The way in which media or communication professions operate.

Convergence has changed the definition of mass communication. The digital mass communication audiences are fragmented but homogeneous. However, the digital environment does not guarantee individual privacy. The geographic, cultural and political borders are of less significance. Media consumption increases, so does the creation and participation of media. Like the conventional media, the digital media also provide the functions of surveillance, correlation, cultural transmission, and entertainment. On several aspects, there is not much difference between digital media theory and conventional media theories.

As regards programme or content availability digital media is decentralised and the process is many to many. The story telling narrative of digital media can be linear or non-linear, and the distribution channels are convergent, digital but often the products are not physical. The supporters of digital media theory argue that these are agents of change – for civil rights, cultural/ethnic identity and also political independence.

Daniel Boorstin coined a word ‘pseudo-events’ for news manufactured or faked. With the arrival of digital media, there is only a thin line of distinction between reality and fake. Scholar Mark Slouka, calls the use of net or virtual reality, as assault on reality. He is worried about the culture of simulation, supported by digitisation that leads to technology abuse and misuse. The manipulated images are believed to be true. Like every other thing in the world, digital media have their own merits and demerits. The vulnerability of human beings in terms of privacy, data and digital divide are real challenges to digital technology and media.

Check Your Progress 3

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answer

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of the unit.

- 1) Delineate the concept of multi-media.

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- 2) Define the term ‘interactivity.’

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- 3) Relate automation with personalisation.

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- 4) List the major sectors of convergence effect.

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10.5 SOCIAL NETWORKING THEORY

In 1960s and 1970s, sociologists shifted their attention from community to inter-personal networks for their research. Fischer and other scholars advocated that interpersonal networks should be studied separately from unitary theories of communities. According to Fischer, inter-personal networks are personal communities. These communities are characterised by intimacy with friends, neighbours and others with voluntary and associative factors. Here the community does not disappear, but is redefined through ‘multiplex, networked, social relations. Wellman has described such a community as a ‘network of networks.’

Accordingly, the composition of networked individualism is the basis of community, instead of large group formations. The concept of networked individualism leads us to the question that how do we understand the line of distinction between ‘local and virtual communities.’ It also poses the question of genuineness of the virtual communities on web. The networked participants on the web are normally linked by common interest. But they may have weak social relations. These virtual communities are an alternative to a locally based physical community.

Social networks are described as the ‘interpersonal relationships people have with friends, family, colleagues, acquaintances, and others they may come into contact with directly or via media communications (Thomas Valente).’ Sociologists have used social network analysis to understand the social relationships, and the individual and social behaviour of the people. Social networks can be analysed at dyadic, group and system levels. The network data are of three types: local, partial and complete.

Online communication is a low-cost channel to communicate with diverse social groups. There is no barrier of space or time. The internet in a way has emerged as a tool of empowerment and expression of individual identities. Social networking sites can be used for advocating or commenting upon macro issues, for example, mobilisation for social political issues, civic participation and for other issues of democratic importance. The success of Arab Spring movement in 2011 was a demonstration of social media credibility to some extent.

According to scholars, there is of course a need to evaluate ‘the new theoretical constructions, ideas of identity, false consciousness, and collective intelligence.....’ Digital communication has its own disadvantages; it is often overcharged by

emotions and represents ‘in the moment’ reactions. As a result, the concept of empowerment through digital means of communication can be a ‘slippery’ notion.

10.5.1 Empowerment

Every theory, from political to feminist, makes use of the term ‘Empowerment’ that contains an element of power in it. When the word ‘empowerment’ is used for the study of social networks, it means the application of the power of individuals to express themselves within an ‘organisational schema’. It can be leading towards activism. What is central to the question of empowerment? It is personal and collective identity. It is also the understanding of ‘belongingness’ or ‘not belonging’, in a communicative context.

The idea of social network is not new. It was used by Durkheim and Tonnies extensively in their sociological writings. In a way, it was in use well before the advent of internet. The term ‘social network’ gained popularity with the arrival of Web 2.0. Specialised social network sites also became popular; this resulted in the intertwining of individuals and the technology. Strange is the fact that the depersonalisation of communication also makes people an element of interaction for empowerment and message exchange. The three important theories of the new interactive communication world are Web Theory, Network Theory and System Theory. These three approaches have also contributed concepts like cybernetics, feedback, and convergence culture.

10.5.2 Issues with Social Networking

There are issues with social networking. Some of these are:

- It empowers some people but disempowers others.
- Power relations do occur.
- Techno-savvy individuals dominate over others who are not.
- Disability divide is a common occurrence.
- Lack of skill may lead to second level digital divide.
- Social networks attract people suffering from social anxiety.
- Anonymity is a critical issue. People may hide behind with fictitious identity or pseudonyms.
- Narcissism is another interesting fall out of social networking.
- It is like ‘first person paparazzi’.
- Contributes to celebrity culture.
- There are gender issues generated by social networks.
- The issue of false consciousness cannot be neglected.
- Some critics argue that the internet has allowed ‘Commodification of Community’.
- Issues related to privacy should also be considered.

We may sum up by saying that virtual communities may exist, but that cannot substitute human communities, despite technological advances, at least in the near future. The control of corporate powerhouses cannot be undermined in virtual communities.

Check Your Progress 4

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) Identify the characteristics of a virtual community.

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2) Explain the concept of ‘empowerment’ in the context of social networking.

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3) List some issues with social networking.

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10.6 GLASGOW SCHOOL OF THOUGHT

The Glasgow University Media Group also known as the Glasgow Media Group, is a group of researchers who came together at Glasgow University in 1974. Its founders are Brian Winston, Greg Philo and John Eldridge. This group is known for pioneering the television news analysis. Balance in media contents, especially news reporting is much debated in both public and academic circles. This is in particular reference to public service broadcasting. We know that print media always claim the ownership of objectivity in news collection, reporting and editing. A newspaper’s institutional voice or opinion is reflected in its editorial comments. The public broadcasting system has its own legal obligation to be fair and balanced in democratic societies. Public access to news and current affairs would enable a comprehensive public debate on issues of importance.

Despite normative control or regulation, the concept of balance has been debated and also challenged. Broadcasters in general argue that the issue of bias is a perceptual problem of the viewers or listeners. In other words, the problem of balance is relative. In western democracies, the political outfits closely monitor the media performance. However, the BBC Guide (1980) says that impartiality does not mean complete neutrality. It says it cannot be neutral when the choices are between truth and untruth, justice and injustice, and tolerance and intolerance. It is observed that the public debate on television news is based on commonsense or otherwise on partisan perceptions. Hard, empirical evidence is normally absent. Yet, substantial academic research has been done using both qualitative and quantitative methods to measure bias or imbalance in television news.

A significant study has been carried out by the Glasgow Media Group on the subject, and a series of books have been published, such as *Bad news* (1976), *More bad news* (1980), and *Really bad news* (1982). This is a longitudinal research of British television news in the second half of the 1970s. It was found that the news coverage highlighted the role of industrial strikes in Britain ignoring the issue of mismanagement and disinvestment in major industries. The management news received greater attention than that of trade unions.

We can find a similar situation in the United States in 1920s. Upton Sinclair, in his book, *The Brass Check*, explained how newspaper stories were manipulated to besmirch labour unions and described them as terrorists and anarchists. Upton Sinclair gave the example of how wire services covered the violence by strikers and their peaceful agitation was ignored. He called it 'capitalist journalism'.

Bias: The stereotypical description of trade unionists as violent criminals still rules the roost. However, the labour challenges of late have become more legal-oriented and the media have also opted for a different type of representation. The Glasgow Media Group, as already stated, demonstrated the partisan coverage of industrial disputes in Great Britain. The credibility of labour unions was always questioned by the British media. For instance, the labour union statements were called 'demands', while the management statements were described as 'offers'. The negative images pervaded not only the news media, but also the films produced.

The restraints that editors and journalists face decide the bias in news. The general political-economic approach describes the news used by capitalists and governments to optimise their interests.

The critical approaches that include Marxist and neo-Marxist slants consider news as a tool of capitalists to maintain the socio-economic status quo. Their question is whether the news clarifies the events in the real world or obscures them. This is part of the critical theory. The Glasgow Media Group analysed the news on labour strikes, the Falklands conflict, and nuclear defence in addition to several political and work related issues. News can be presented even with the capitalist systems and nation states. A few scholars have also considered media audience as passive consumers, susceptible for media manipulation and infotainment. It is pertinent to observe here that the Glasgow Media Group conducted an interesting content analysis in 1970 that inquired into the 'evidence of ideological bias of broadcasting' while dealing with industrial and economic affairs. The group has also worked on TV news and the public understanding of Palestinian issue, specifically its conflict with Israel.

Check Your Progress 5

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answer with those given at the end of the unit.

1) Outline the need for balance in news.

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10.7 CHICAGO SCHOOL OF THOUGHT

John Dewey, Charles Cooley and George Mead were the great thinkers of Chicago School who helped us understand the relationship between communication and society. The School propounded that ‘media and communication play a central role in shaping individual and collective lives, and in cementing identities and communities. One cannot understand society without understanding how we communicate with each other and how the media shape our social bonds and social worlds’. The School has contributed in understanding the role of media in society and has build scholarship in analysing media from sociological perspective.

Symbolic interactionism dealing with social interactions is a seminal work of Chicago School lead by George Mead. Symbolic interaction was an early social science theory to analyse the ways of learning culture and the way culture builds our daily life. An early nomenclature for it was social behaviourism. George Herbert Mead (1934) of Chicago University was a professor of philosophy besides being a social activist. He, like other social behaviourists, rejected the simple notions of stimulus-response conditioning. According to Mead, all of us learn of social roles by interacting with others, all our actions are conditioned by others.

10.7.1 Interactionism

George Mead, the founder of symbolic interactionism, argues that symbols transform the process of socialisation. Symbolic Interactionism is a sociological theory that focuses on the relationships among people in a society. There are patterns of interaction between individuals say social scientists.

Language and symbols are the means of communication and people understand the meaning through symbols in social world. His hypothesis, called symbolic interactionism, says that a person’s understanding of physical reality is controlled or mediated by the symbolic environment of the mind, self and society. For example we choose to read a book or visit a place based on interaction with a friend and the friend is also influenced by some similar social behavioural pattern. In another example, take a political protest rally where a symbolic interactionist is interested in understanding how protests in groups interact, and what symbols they use to communicate the protest message. Protesters holding candle march and lighting candles in a conflict zone communicate even intangible emotions through symbols. The research methodology is qualitative consisting of participant observation.

Mead sourced ideas to develop symbolic interactionism from pragmatism. Pragmatism is a philosophical school of theory advocates that knowledge should be used to act on things with emphasis on practice and an idea or theory is born out of practice. Mead said that individuals will have some control over their actions. However, for him, the agency of control was with the community itself.

Community produces and promotes culture, which has complex sets of symbols. It guides and shapes our day-to-day experiences. Many prominent symbolic integrationists were with the University of Chicago. They came to be known as the Chicago School and made arguments with regard to the social responsibility of the press, a normative theory.

10.7.2 Performance

Social responsibility of the press was deliberated by scholars in early 1940s. Hutchins Commission on Freedom of the Press had suggested that an extensive local coverage would permit pluralistic communities to know each other. However, the Chicago newspapers did not show much interest in this proposal. The focus of newspapers was on crime and social unrest and also on the suburban rich. Ethnic neighbourhoods were totally ignored by the press.

Chicago School dismissed the notion that media is a market place of ideas but argued that unregulated mass media will serve the interests of political power wielding elite groups than marginalised groups. It underlined that people will use media to stay in power and gain access to political corridors than to serve small, poor minority communities. History is known of Hitler who abused media to arouse hatred against the Jews.

Another area of Chicago School research was the community interaction. The idea of community integration acquired recognition in mass communication research in 1960s. Communication scholars concentrated on the identified processes to predict local community integration and interest in local issues besides civic participation.

In the early 1970s, the concept of community re-emerged as a 'network of networks' and virtual communities. It was also a study of the relationship among communities in terms of space, place, and virtual communities. Janowitz of the post-war 'second Chicago School' attempted to locate media sources of community integration. He preferred the local urban weeklies to fulfill the needs of the more homogeneous neighbourhoods.

Check Your Progress 6

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) What was the view of G.H. Mead on stimulus-response conditioning?

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2) What does the statement 'Symbols are both arbitrary and abstract' mean?

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- 3) Explain another contribution of Chicago School for communication studies?

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10.8 LET US SUM UP

The academic discipline of mass communication has its own diverse theories encompassing structural, political, economic, and socio-cultural and role performance related aspects. We have both European and American traditions of theoretical perspectives of mass media. A critical theory questions the status quo and provides alternate ways of interpreting the social role of mass media. Cultural imperialism is also called a critical theory. The Frankfurt School was known for its neo-Marxist theory, popular during 1920s and 1930s and was the first to consider mass media as a culture industry.

Characterised by multi-media, interactivity, automation, personalisation and convergence, digital media changed the very process of mass communication. The digital media also offer the functions of surveillance, correlation, cultural transmission and entertainment like the conventional media. Privacy is a serious issue in the digital environment.

In 1960 and 1970s, sociologists shifted their focus from community to inter-personal networks for research. The inter-personal networks were personal communities featured by intimacy with friends, neighbours, and others. Such a community was called 'network of networks'. One of the effects of online social networking is empowerment, activism can be another consequence.

The Glasgow University Media Group came into being in 1974 and pioneered the television news analysis. Balance in media contents, particularly in new reporting was much debated. Alternative views were published for the sake of balance and pluralism. The analysis news highlighted the bias of British media as to the industrial strikes in Britain, ignoring the issue of mismanagement and critical of trade unions. The Chicago School of thought analysed symbolic interactionism. George Herbert Mead rejected the simple notions of stimulus - response conditioning. Mead provided an important insight into the process of socialisation. Symbols make human beings different. A person's understanding of physical reality is controlled by the symbolic environment the mind, self and society. Robert E. Park, another prominent member of Chicago School, indirectly studied the functions of the newspaper press in cities. Observation as a method of research is the contribution of this School which was used to study audience behaviour.

10.9 FURTHER READINGS

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10.10 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

- 1) The main characteristics of critical theory are:
 - It studies the role of mass media in human society.
 - It uses a definite set of values and uses them to attack the existing system.
 - It evaluates specific social institutions to know how far the valued objectives are achieved.
- 2) The areas that come under the label of critical theories are: Social movements, spin doctoring, media ownership, cultural imperialism, cultural flow and political economy.
- 3) Max Horkheimer and Theodor Adorno considered mass media as a culture industry. They wanted to keep up the promise of freedom alive against the supremacy of instrumental reason. It was a criticism of capitalism. They opposed the commodification of media.

Check Your Progress 2

- 1) The Frankfurt School was known for its neo-Marxist theory. It integrated Marxist critical theory with hermeneutic theory.
- 2) Horkheimer and Adorno analysed the larger content producing industries. They equated mass media with culture industry as according to them, media have a mesmerising effect on an innocent audience and converts them into subordination.
- 3) European scholars thought that the mass media contributed to the development of mass culture, while American scholars thought that mass media prompted the arrival of class culture. This distinction was in fact a conflict between Marxism and free enterprise system.

Check Your Progress 3

- 1) The multi-media concept combines various media into a single entity in which pictures, text, sound and graphics are merged together.
- 2) Interactivity is described as a dialogue between a human being and a computer programme.

- 3) Computers are automated to perform many complex functions. Automation has led to the personalisation of online media.
- 4) The major sectors that have experienced the effect of convergence are:
 - The communication content
 - The relationship between media houses and their users
 - The structure of media/communication organisation
 - The way in which media professionals operate.

Check Your Progress 4

- 1) Virtual communities are groups of people on the web. They are linked together because of common interests, ethnicity and weak social relations. They are alternatives to physical communities.
- 2) In the virtual community, there is no barrier of space and time. The individual messages, opinions and preferences can be sent across distribution networks. The concept of empowerment has the element of power which can lead to activism.
- 3) Some issues with social networking are:
 - It empowers only some people
 - Tech-savvy individuals dominate others who are not
 - Disability divide may occur
 - Second level digital divide is possible
 - Anonymity and narcissism are critical issues
 - Celebrity culture and commodification of community can be some other effects.

Check Your Progress 5

- 1) Balance in news media contents is important. Newspapers claim the ownership of objectivity. Public broadcasters argue that balance is a perceptual problem. Media need fairness and balance in news reporting to enhance their credibility.
- 2) The Glasgow Media Group is known for pioneering television news analysis. The research found bias in the reporting of trade union strikes in Britain by the media.

Check Your Progress 6

- 1) George Herbert Mead of Chicago University rejected the simple notions of stimulus-response conditioning and argued that all of us learn of our social roles by interacting with others.
- 2) Mead argues that symbols transform the process of socialisation. All our responses to symbols are mediated by those very symbols. We give meanings to symbols.
- 3) Another important contribution of the Chicago School is using observation as a method of communication studies. Behaviour of media audience is studied with this method.

UNIT 11 CULTURAL STUDIES

Structure

- 11.0 Introduction
- 11.1 Learning Outcomes
- 11.2 Theories of Culture
 - 11.2.1 Culture as Structural System
 - 11.2.2 Culture as Symbolic System
 - 11.2.3 Culture as Cognitive System
- 11.3 Initial Debates
 - 11.3.1 The Emergence and History of Cultural Studies
 - 11.3.2 Post-modern Understanding of Cultural Studies
- 11.4 Approaches to Cultural Studies
 - 11.4.1 Classical Marxism
 - 11.4.2 Frankfurt School
 - 11.4.3 Hegemony
 - 11.4.4 Post-Marxism
- 11.5 Context, Trajectories and Aesthetics
 - 11.5.1 Contextual Cultural Studies
 - 11.5.2 Trajectories of Cultural Studies
 - 11.5.3 Aesthetics in Cultural Studies
- 11.6 Let Us Sum Up
- 11.7 Further Readings
- 11.8 Key Terms
- 11.9 Check Your Progress: Possible Answers

11.0 INTRODUCTION

Cultural studies emerged as a multidisciplinary subject during 1950s with its roots in the Centre for Contemporary Studies in Birmingham. It gained importance in the field of communication studies in the beginning of the last quarter of twentieth century. Theories concerned with cultural studies focus on the ways people produce new culture by using media, which shapes their everyday life. It does not concern itself with how media brings in a change in the social order. Instead as a micro-level theory, cultural studies lay emphasis on larger issues favouring the living patterns of people. It does not have a clear subject matter and thus lacks principles, theories and the method. It borrows them freely from other social science disciplines such as sociology, anthropology, psychology, among others.

11.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After studying this unit, you should be able to:

- define the notion of cultural studies;
- trace the emergence and history of cultural studies;

- discuss the approaches and theories of cultural studies;
- contextualise cultural studies;
- explain the trajectories in the study of cultural studies: and
- analyse the idea of aesthetics within the cultural studies.

11.2 THEORIES OF CULTURE

There is an ambiguity over the understanding of cultural theory in the sense that whether it is a theory of culture or if the study of culture itself constitutes a theory. Cultural theorists trace the developmental aspects of cultural theory from the evolutionary perspective. There are scholars, however, who try to see culture through two different lenses, the ideational and the adaptationist lens. We will keep our focus here on the ideational approaches of culture, which is more often dealt with by the cultural theorists who envisage culture as ideational. Here we shall discuss and distinguish three rather different ways of approaching culture through ideational perspective, that is, culture as structural system, symbolic system and cognitive system.

11.2.1 Culture as Structural System

People from different cultural backgrounds have different perceptions about the society they live in. But how they perceive the society is largely rooted in the structure of that culture. The structure of different cultures which are cognizant and naïve at the same time determines the functioning of the world system thus making culture unique. This results in a collective action of various cultures, which otherwise is difficult for the non-members to comprehend. This aspect of the structure of culture offers an insight into examining different facets of culture such as aesthetics, ethics, nature, and so on which further help people derive the meanings out of their lives. This means that there are certain institutions central to the structure of culture and members of every cultural group communicate with these institutions, which further attaches meanings to their lives.

Levi Strauss's contribution to the structural aspects of culture evolves through his elaboration of the structural analysis of world and its course of development. Such a structuralist method has tremendously shaped the ways scholars within the American tradition have analysed the culture's structure. At the core of Strauss's writings is the culture and mind. The notions of culture are comprehended through structures, which are the creation of human mind. Strauss attempts to trace structures within the cultural domains, such as art and language as the tenets of mind, in order to produce culturally constructed structures. These culturally constructed structures, which can be categorised and understood at three levels play an essential role in redefining the culture of people.

Let us take the example of a media industry. While we may have our own identities at home or in our societies/communities but upon being appointed to serve in a certain media company, we are directed to follow the rules/codes of that company such as the dress code, the ethics, the language, and so on. All these transformations can be understood at three levels, that is, at the organisational level (such as the strategies and hierarchy), at the group level (such as power, conflict, competition) and at the individual level (such as motivation, attitude, ability to learn and so on). These processes of mind and of the physical entities

elaborate into a formally similar model for all the individuals. These impositions, however, are arbitrary and there is always a vacuum between the cultural formal impositions and the cultural social impositions. However, Strauss argued that these structures are overlapping and they transcend both the spaces – formal and social – to avoid the cultural division of people in a setting.

11.2.2 Culture as Symbolic System

The second theory of culture is concerned with the symbolic system, which though connects to the theory of structure, however, views culture as a set of symbols. Culture in the form of symbols is a means of communication among people from various groups and this is central to the formation of collective culture. Generally, we are surrounded by symbols comprising of tangible objects, which symbolise abstract objects without any relationship between the two. Anthropologists argue that human evolution is surrounded by certain experiences, which people symbolically communicate. A common example of such symbols is the written text in its tangible form, but it can also be intangible. Since language is learned, its symbolic forms developed but is independent of the evolution of human beings. This reflects that language as an element of culture can reach members of various cultural groups.

Symbols can also be in the form of artifacts such as rituals, designs of a building, tools, and so on. These forms of symbols can be classified into two categories, that is, material culture and symbolic culture. This classification is based on the fact that symbols comprise and represent a variety of data and therefore to study them requires a number of distinct methodologies. Comprehending and using cultural symbols is instrumental to their expression. People attach meanings to symbols, which differ from what actually is depicted through them. For this reason, the interpretation of the symbols differs among people in two different contexts. First, that people belonging to different cultural groups are likely to interpret the symbols in their own ways, which are different from the other. Secondly, people from even one cultural background are also likely to differ in their interpretations and expressions of the symbols depending upon the cultural contexts in which the symbols are used by them.

There are the two methods to comprehend, express, and communicate the intangible elements of culture, that is, symbols and language. Symbols can be anything, which corresponds to some specific meaning. Language consists of symbols used to communicate ideas and opinions with the members of same cultural group. While meanings are derived from the language by the members of a particular linguistic group, symbols do not carry any meanings on their own. It is the human endeavour, a two way process: 1) to attach meanings to the symbols and 2) communicating the attached meanings to other members of their cultural group. Multi-linguistic cultural groups have the potential of communicating ideas with people from diverse cultures, and this enhances the tolerance power among people belonging to different cultural groups. Cultural symbols at the same time communicate strong meanings, which shape the thinking process and govern the behaviour of people in certain specified ways. Symbols acquire value through instilling them with human beliefs, emotions, and ideas.

11.2.3 Culture as Cognitive System

Cognitive system functions in line with inherently structured schema and its main performative aspects include imparting of culture. The usage of cognitive system is dominant in psychology and other disciplines such as anthropology, political science, education, linguistics, and so on. Within media and communication studies, this theory of culture offers insights into how media affects audiences but until now cognitive theories have least affected media studies. In fact the cognitive aspects of cultures have limited itself to the spheres of semantics. Thus the question arises if at all media studies require cognitive theories, other than the one offered by Habermas. Cognitive system is an extensive field and it is difficult to find a suitable cognitive theory that would best fit in communication studies. Cognition is all about how human mind functions concerning the process of evolving ideas, conceptions, metaphors, dreams, and so on. A distinction needs to be made here between cognition and the allied term emotion where the former is a constituent of what is rational and the latter is irrational.

Within cultural studies, according to Stuart Hall (1986), understanding cognitive aspects of culture is irrelevant. The focus of cognition instead lies with the practices of everyday life. There is a difference in the two fold understanding of culture that is cognitive and interpretative. The distinction between the two can be made at four fronts, that is, conceptual approach, area of research, site of analysis and the system of methodology. The conceptual approach focuses on how to conceptualise culture and the ways of developing a socio-cultural system. The area of research are different for both cognitive and interpretative studies in the sense that the former centers around people's beliefs to understand their culture while the latter involves behaviour of people belonging to the same cultural group which gives meaning to their culture. The site of analysis or what is also called as the focal point of analysis informs the difference in the cultural patterns at both interpretative and cognitive levels.

The key to understand culture from the interpretive perspective is the symbolic disposition of behaviours by the members of a community. From the cognitive point of view, culture is a social construction, created by members of a community. The cognitive is concerned with the methodological aspects. The interpretive dimension relies on ethnographic enquiries to understand culture and to uncover the factors that contribute towards building a cultural society. On the other hand, the cognitive field entails field experiments through statistical devices in order to explain how culture is constructed in the minds of people belonging to one cultural group.

In the next section, we will discuss the initial debates concerning cultural studies.

Check Your Progress 1

Notes: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those ones given at the end of this Unit.

1) Briefly explain how do people derive meaning out of their lives?

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- 2) According to Levi Strauss, what is best way to understand the notions of culture?

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- 3) What are symbols?

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- 4) Define cognition.

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11.3 INITIAL DEBATES

The general conception of cultural studies is most often borrowed from E.B. Tylor's anthropological definition: "that complex whole which includes knowledge, belief, art, morals, law, custom, and any other capabilities and habits' acquired by members of a given society" (Tylor, 1958 [1871]: 1). Taylor has not limited the 'complex whole' to the elements mentioned in the definition but also included traditions shared by the members of a community, their ideas and values which are central to social interaction. But the notions of culture are no longer confined to the elements pointed out by Tylor. Limiting our understanding of the culture to the definition offered by Tylor is not enough since the ways of understanding culture through innovative ways are coming into being. In this discussion, let us move on to understand the history of cultural studies in the following section.

11.3.1 The Emergence and History of Cultural Studies

The emergence of cultural studies is traced to mid-1950s through the works of Richard Hoggart (*Uses of Literacy*) and Raymond Williams (*Culture and Society*). Cultural studies developed gradually with roots in Britain's Centre for Contemporary Studies in Birmingham, established in 1964. The emerging works concerning cultural studies are theoretically applied to the understanding of various facets of everyday life. The pioneers of cultural studies in Britain are R. Hoggart, R. Williams, E.P. Thompson and S. Hall. Their works provide the basis to the analysis of cultural studies. Cultural studies grew during 1960s in West along with popular culture. The Birmingham Centre for Contemporary Studies carried out projects using various approaches between 1970 and 1980, which received deep encouragement from R. Williams and S. Hall. Cultural studies developed out of the theoretical insights and approaches borrowed from post-structuralism, textuality, and discourse analysis respectively. These latter two approaches still hold significance in cultural studies.

Cultural studies in Britain are at the core, while we attempt to trace the emergence of cultural studies in India, which scholars argue developed within the disciplines such as cinema studies, art history, and so on. In the contemporary times, popular culture such as films, ads, news reports, and new media are the chief elements used in cultural studies. However, cultural studies as studied in India differ in the ways it is studied in the West (Niranjana, 2012). Niranjana used feminist model in her study to trace the interconnection between feminism and cultural studies. This study is more so in Asian context, which does not exclude Indian notions of cultural studies, the commonalities being marginality, minority, ethnicity, and so on. The year 1990 marks the beginning of cultural studies in India, a period when television was in the process of its growth.

11.3.2 Post-modern Understanding of Cultural Studies

The shift to postmodern cultural studies is the result of global capitalism existent in the contemporary times. In its present phase, there is a common trend of completely overlooking certain disciplines so that stress is laid upon the formation of cross-cultural identities from what is termed popular culture. Such a formation reiterates the post-modern shift and detaches it from Marxism, liberalism, and reductionism. The shift towards cultural populism (i.e. audience) is a shift towards postmodern cultural studies and is explicit in the works of critical theorists like Fredric Jameson (1991, 1998). Both cultural studies and postmodernism though have the common intellectual memoirs, however, the former distances itself from the latter on the ground that the latter has completely dislocated the two-fold class relations, which is central to the cultural studies' identity politics. As a result of this, "cultural studies declares war against postmodernism" (Haslop, 1996: 376).

There is yet another postmodern turn wherein the process of reformation of cultural studies is a response of the disputes in postmodernism. In his attempt, Grossberg (1993) tried to reconsider the British cultural studies because of the new postmodern condition. Realising that there are a numerous discussions and contestations about British cultural studies, Grossberg (1993) engaged in finding an interconnection between cultural studies and postmodernism to let the former partake in the postmodern disputes and act accordingly.

There are thus various opposing spheres of postmodern cultural studies. Dialectically, postmodernism as a theory ensures rethinking cultural criticism in the present context.

Check Your Progress 2

Notes: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those ones given at the end of this Unit.

1) Define Culture as defined by E.B. Tylor.

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2) The shift towards cultural populism is a shift towards

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11.4 APPROACHES TO CULTURAL STUDIES

In this section, we will discuss the major approaches of cultural studies. Though there can be different approaches, the focus here will be on four important approaches of cultural studies, namely, Classical Marxism, Frankfurt School, Hegemony, and Post Marxism. Some of these approaches have been discussed elsewhere in this course; here we shall look at them from the perspective of cultural studies.

11.4.1 Classical Marxism

There are varied accounts of cultural studies that emerged till today. Between 1980 and 1990, a period of global expansion, the only approach that cultural studies could be identified with was culture and society through its various socio-political materialist approaches vis-à-vis cultural Marxism. Theorists of 20th century such as Lukacs, Gramsci, Adorno, and others used Marxian theory in their analysis of culture within the production system and how it influenced audiences and their everyday life. Generally, the forms of culture according to Marxian approach evolved explicitly in certain historical situations. These forms of culture are ideological which according to Marx are beneficial for ruling class because it legitimises the domination within the class structure. Ideology holds significance in Marxist approach to cultural studies because it helps distinguish the dominant ideas from those of the non-ruling class and promote interests of the ruling class.

Classical Marxist approach to cultural studies asserts that the analysis of language and cultural practices must be done in accordance with the historical conditions laid down for the production system. For Marx, history is all about the modes of production – the modes of society, feudal, and capitalist; it is about the production of necessities for everyday living, formation of relationships and so on. More precisely, it informs about how to establish the relationships, especially among the ruling and non-ruling class, how to get the needs of living fulfilled and also the formation of socio-cultural institutions. Classical Marxism helps determine the social, cultural and political aspects of a society through ways by which the means of living are produced. Classical Marxism as an approach to cultural studies asserts that text can always be understood in its historicity, which has economy as its base. Therefore, culture passively becomes the reflection of economy.

Means of production in media and communication studies comprises mass media according to the classical Marxism with media owners as the dominant class and forming capitalist society. Mass media produces false consciousness among the working class, which are the manifestations of capitalists. This debars the idea of media diversity and the process of meaning-making remains at risk. However, Stuart Hall (1986) contends that mass media reproduces the meanings, which in itself are an ideological struggle because it is beneficial for dominant class only.

11.4.2 Frankfurt School

Frankfurt School is not an institution but a school of thought. As discussed in the previous unit, it includes German intellectuals such as Max Horkheimer, Theodore Adorno and Herbert Marcuse who worked at the Frankfurt Institute for Social Research founded in 1923. Frankfurt School developed a model for the cultural studies to examine the process through which cultures are produced. In 1930, this school developed a transdisciplinary approach to cultural studies and communication studies through the amalgamation of political economy and analysis of ideological elements. The mass production of cultures within the industry led them to call it as 'culture industry', which ideologically legitimises the capitalist societies and results in a common mode of living within it.

According to this school, there is no or little difference between the capitalised commercial mass media and other natural commodities. There is a commonality between mass media and other commodities in the sense that both are beneficial for the capitalists. Mass media depends heavily on the capital, which is crucial for the functioning of mass media. This contradicts the idea of freedom of mass media, which therefore is just an illusion. According to Frankfurt School, culture industry stays aspiring for the creation of a better world. The Frankfurt School theorists were of the notion that people are capable of creating their own world of comfort. However, they were also of the belief that this aim cannot be achieved in a world where culture is commodified.

According to them, media industry heavily depends on powerful sectors like telecommunications and banks as their economies are interwoven. Frankfurt School has contributed tremendously in our understanding of culture through ways in which culture is commodified, and commercialised for economic pursuits. The School draws attention towards the cultures in industrialised societies where people think about themselves and about the culture controlled by capitalists, which they consume. The false consciousness and the false needs offered by the culture industry serves the capitalists in making their interests. In short, Frankfurt School enables us to understand how culture industry functions.

11.4.3 Hegemony

Hegemony refers to a class of people who use their ideas and norms to rule the world. In other words, hegemony means ideological and cultural domination. This position in a society is generally achieved through certain institutions supporting those in power to control the rest of the people. Cultural hegemony works by considering the views of capitalists and their socio-economic structures as legitimate and beneficial to all, while these structures are beneficial only to those in power. There is, however, difference in how military dictators and the ruling class use force to control the society. The dominant class generally uses such power in its intangible form as a peaceful way of ruling through culture and ideology.

An Italian Marxist philosopher Antonio Gramsci developed the idea of cultural hegemony. The Marxian theory, states that dominant ideology in any society is the one, which reflects the culture of the ruling class. This view of hegemony denotes that various existing cultures in any society can be governed and dominated by one class, that is, the ruling class. According to Gramsci, power as

a means of domination is to influence the rest of society and this power is temporary. It is never permanent and cannot be restricted to a single class.

Considering the Marxian division of state which is twofold, that is, base and superstructure, Gramsci divides superstructure into political and civil society the former being a coercive institution while as the latter non-coercive. This analytical view of hegemony by Gramsci vis-à-vis other interrelated conceptions such as ideology, intellectuals, etc. though developed in European culture, find relevance in media and communication studies also.

11.4.4 Post-Marxism

Post-Marxism marked an entry into the scholarly world to engage with the classical Marxism and the Western Marxism. Post-Marxist approach of cultural studies explicitly deals with the questions concerning political and ethical. It is closely associated with the cultural studies and so allows for an explanation of the relationship between structures, power and subjectivity which is different from the one offered by classical social sciences. Cultural studies developed through borrowing methods from politics, one method among which is post-Marxism. The traces of this approach are manifested within the cultural studies with a theoretical turn. Post-Marxist theory of politics can be found in the works of three political theorists Ernesto Laclau, Judith Butler, and Slavoj Žižek who discarded the classical Marxist approach emphasising class struggle and power relations. Among these three post-Marxist theorists, Laclau's (1990) theory has marked its entrance into media studies during the last two decades. Elucidating on 'post' in Post-Marxism, Laclau, says that 'post' is not a critique or abandonment of Marxism or surpassing Marxism, but an approach beyond what was constituted by classical Marxists (Laclau, 1990).

The vanishing of the classical Marxism is the result of criticism to the notion of ideology given by Althusser. During 1960's, Althusser asserted that there can be no pull-apart of the ideas of personal and political. As an anti-essentialist approach, Post-Marxists do not consider class, society, or history as universal or pre-discursive groups. Highly influenced by the Gramscian hegemony, post-Marxist theory treats culture and ideology isolated from the economic base. In his challenge to the economic determinism of classical Marxism, Gramsci asserts that the class rule can only be maintained through a revised form of hegemony. Gramsci finally argues that various hegemonic forms are created by organic intellectuals to set the foundation for some specific historic bloc.

Check Your Progress 3

Notes: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those ones given at the end of this Unit.

1) What is classical Marxism?

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- 2) What is the contribution of Frankfurt School towards cultural studies?

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- 3) What is hegemony?

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- 4) Discuss few commonalities between British School and Frankfurt School.

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11.5 CONTEXT, TRAJECTORIES AND AESTHETICS

Culture as a concept is considered as subtle, the conceptualisation of which is intricate. Despite this, culture continues to be an important object of examination. Let us try to understand the contextual issues in cultural studies and look at the trajectories of aesthetics in this section.

11.5.1 Contextual Cultural Studies

Scholars argue that culture is constructed and this acts as a solid base to identify ways through which some representations appear potent than others. It also accentuates that our societies have transformed into a network of cultures that incite numerous discourses other than cultural ones. The idea of using critical intercultural framework is to unfold what representations of culture appear real and what are the processes to ascertain the reality of these cultures.

The critical notion of cultural studies is borrowed from the notions of hegemony as propounded by Gramsci (1971). Hegemony portrays culture, politics, and society as a ground of contestation for various groups and classes. Various individuals attempted to construct a separate model of ideology that would pay more attention to hegemonic ideologies of neo-capitalists (Hall, 1986). Such an extension of ideology is critical to this idea. It grounds ideology in a context where political conflict occurs. For this reason, we can see media culture as an area which is challenging in the sense that it is the reason for conflicts in a society but not the means of dominance. Thus instead of treating ideology as an instrument of domination for the ruling class, it can also be contextualised relationally as a counter to the resistance and an opposition to the hegemonic nature of dominant class.

11.5.2 Trajectories of Cultural Studies

The British cultural studies, since its inception in the Birmingham School, has remained oriented towards political with focus on hegemonic potentials against other subcultures. It values all the subcultures from youth sub-culture to the working class culture, and encourages them to oppose the dominating nature of capitalists. Youth culture according to British cultural studies offers innovative ways to stand against the capitalist culture through resistance and change. This led the British cultural studies to determine how culture creates distinct forms of identities. These identities differ culturally from one group to the other. People who obey the cultural codes of ruling class construct their identities within the dominant groups as opposed to other sub-cultural groups who also construct their own identities, which are in opposition to the mainstream identities.

British cultural studies failed to deal effectively with art, aesthetics, and modernism. It has narrowed down its scope by restricting to media culture. Frankfurt School on the other hand had a broad vision of being more productive, and this school engaged with all that is not dealt by British School – modernism, high culture, and so on. However, both these schools, which are primarily transdisciplinary, stressed that culture must only be studied within the socio-political context which produces it and where it is consumed.

Recently, there has been a change in the cultural studies in terms of the language which is a postmodern challenge with emphasis on identity formation. Media culture has a role to play from this viewpoint so to say in the production process, which supplies material for the formation of identities, which further constitutes what is called ‘popular’. The constitution of ‘popular’ is realised through the consumption of cultural products. Thus, there has been a shift from the previous socialist and revolutionary politics to the identity politics.

11.5.3 Aesthetics in Cultural Studies

The notions of aesthetics are closely connected with media studies. Aesthetics is central to modern cultural industries and to the media created by people through digitalisation. The prominent feature of cultural studies is the fact that it has embraced multiple voices of people who make a shift from other disciplines to cultural studies and often explicate the freedom of expressing in different voices. What is aesthetic in these expressions using multiple voices is the outcome, which determines the structure of the text of these voices. It is often impossible to consider experiences in isolation to what has been achieved in the past through training and education; those experiences, which have not been shaped by the knowledge and ideology one has accomplished. Contrary to this, there are theorists from varied disciplines such as psychology, geography and anthropology who have determined the extent to which cultures affect perceptions. Aesthetic insight, however, is significant to understand experience because it offers a dominant way of reviewing culture based experiences by sliding under accumulated meanings and cognitive practices.

In order to engage with the idea of aesthetics in culture, there are three distinct stages of investigation, that is, experience, theory and metaesthetic theory. The first is experience – the aesthetics of culture, which represents culturally adapted experience characterising the means through which culture is perceived aesthetically. The second stage entails the need to acknowledge the pluralist and

inclusive nature of aesthetic theory. The third level, that is, metaesthetic theory is subtle yet captivating that looks for the key structures shared by different cultural aesthetics.

Check Your Progress 4

Notes: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those ones given at the end of this Unit.

1) In the Trajectories what is the essence of British cultural studies?

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2) How is aesthetics in cultural studies connected with media?

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11.6 LET US SUM UP

In this unit, we have traced the emergence of cultural studies as a theory which has its roots in British Centre for Contemporary Studies, Birmingham. The unit also traces the history of cultural studies and how it developed over a period of time, globally as well as in India. The pioneers of cultural studies are Hoggart, Williams, Thompson and Hall. They have remarkably contributed towards this new theory through their modes of analysing culture. The unit offers three theoretical insights of culture in addition to the approaches through which we can comprehend cultural studies. Further, we have dealt with the contextual issues in cultural studies in addition to emphasising on the trajectories of aesthetics in cultural studies. The unit attempts to enlighten you about the culture of media and communication which can be located within the contexts of social, economic and political contexts, whereas the medium itself is a constituent of culture.

11.7 FURTHER READINGS

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11.8 KEY TERMS

Culture: A set of knowledge, beliefs, art, morals, law, custom, etc.

Symbol: Anything that represents other things.

Ideology: A system of ideas and beliefs, which acts as a basis for the formation of theory.

Cognition: Process of acquiring knowledge through experiences and thought processes.

Structure: A complex whole of various parts, where each part is functionally connected with the other.

Hegemony: Ideological domination or ruling the world through one's ideas and norms.

11.9 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

- 1) Communication among members of various cultural groups through different aspects of culture such as aesthetics, ethics, nature, and so on to help people derive meanings out of their lives.
- 2) According to Levi Strauss, the notions of culture can be best understood through its structures.
- 3) Symbols are material and non-material objects carrying some specific meaning and used to communicate ideas and opinions among members of a cultural group.
- 4) Cognition is the functioning of human mind in terms of the production of ideas, conceptions, metaphors, dreams, and so on.

Check Your Progress 2

- 1) According to E.B. Tylor, culture can be defined as “that complex whole which includes knowledge, belief, art, morals, law, custom, and any other capabilities and habits’ acquired by members of a given society”.
- 2) Post-modern cultural studies.
- 3) The shift towards post-modern cultural studies is the result of global capitalism prevalent in contemporary world.

Check Your Progress 3

- 1) Classical Marxism is an approach which helps determine the social, cultural and political aspects of a society through ways by which the means of living are produced.

Critical and Cultural Theories

- 2) Frankfurt School developed an approach for cultural studies called transdisciplinary approach to examine the process through which cultures are produced through the amalgamation of political economy and analysis of ideological elements.
- 3) Hegemony means ideological and cultural domination. It involves a class of people who use their ideas and norms to rule the world.
- 4) The commonalities in British School and Frankfurt School are that both are primarily transdisciplinary and both stressed that culture must only be studied within the socio-political context which produces and consumes it.

Check Your Progress 4

- 1) British cultural studies is oriented towards political with focus on hegemonic potentials against other subcultures. It values all the subcultures from youth sub-culture to the working class culture, and encourages them to oppose the dominating nature of capitalists.
- 2) Aesthetics is central to modern cultural industries and to the media created by people through digitalisation. The prominent feature of cultural studies is the fact that it has embraced multiple voices of people who make a shift from other disciplines to cultural studies and often explicate the freedom of expressing in different voices.

UNIT 12 POLITICAL ECONOMY THEORY

Structure

- 12.0 Introduction
- 12.1 Learning Outcomes
- 12.2 Political Economy Perspective in Communications Research
 - 12.2.1 Critical Perspective of Political Economy
 - 12.2.2 Characteristics of the Political Economy Approach
- 12.3 The Propaganda Model
- 12.4 Political Economy and Economic Power of Media
 - 12.4.1 Government
 - 12.4.2 Advertising
 - 12.4.3 Media Ownership
 - 12.4.4 Social and Economic Context
 - 12.4.5 Paid News
- 12.5 Public Interest vs Business Interest
- 12.6 Cultural Imperialism
- 12.7 Let Us Sum Up
- 12.8 Further Readings
- 12.9 Key Terms
- 12.10 Check Your Progress: Possible Answers

12.0 INTRODUCTION

Political economy is a critical approach that provides you knowledge and a forum for the current debates and arguments on political and economic traditions and is used to study power relations. Specifically in communications research, the political economy approach is used to examine the historical, social, economic and political context within which media products are created and consumed. This theory focuses on media institutions and how they are impacted by as well as themselves impact government policy, economic structures and historical precedents. For researchers and practitioners, the political economy approach offers an important perspective of the larger ecosystem surrounding media production and consumption. In this unit, we shall discuss the political economy approach in communication in detail with specific reference to international and Indian media.

12.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After working through this unit, you should be able to:

- describe the political economy approach;
- differentiate between celebratory and critical research;
- discuss the characteristics of the political economy approach;
- describe some theoretical frameworks in political economy;

- analyse how political economy of the media is related to its economic power;
- discuss 'vital tension' in the media between public interest and business interest; and
- describe the phenomenon of cultural imperialism.

12.2 POLITICAL ECONOMY PERSPECTIVE IN COMMUNICATION RESEARCH

The political economy approach to communications research "...uncovers connections between ownership, corporate structure, finance capital, and market structures to show how economics affects technologies, politics, cultures, and information" (Meehan, Mosco and Wasko, 1993, p. 105). In general, the political economic approach explores "the study of the social relations, particularly power relations, that mutually constitute the production, distribution and consumption of resources" (Mosco, 1996, p. 25). In essence, this approach leads us to examine "why we get what we get" (Meehan, Mosco and Wasko, 1993, p.105).

The political economy approach is considered to have four "essential dimensions" that include history, social totality, moral philosophy and praxis (Meehan, Mosco and Wasko, 1993). Meehan et al emphasise that understanding history helps to avoid the pitfalls of static models preferred by economists. The social totality dimension is more specifically defined as "understanding the relationship among commodities, institutions, social relations, and hegemony" (p.107). Through this we explore connections between structures, practices, the flow of goods (and information) and power. Moral philosophy is described as including the concepts of "justice, equity and the public good" (Golding and Murdock, 1991). These are not merely abstract concepts but very real issues in modern democracies around the world grappling with issues of inequality and improving the living standards of millions of citizens. Praxis bridges the gap between research and social intervention (Meehan, Mosco and Wasko, 1993). The political economy approach is thus not limited to academic intellectual activity but aims to create knowledge that can be used in 'real world' interventions. Directing our attention to the close connection between politics and economics, Wasko (2003) observes, "Indeed, the politics cannot be separated from the economics." Given these four dimensions and the wide areas of interest generated through this framework, it comes as no surprise to learn that political economy uses methods from fields as varied as history, economics, political science and sociology (Wasko, 2004).

Guback's (1969) book on the international film industry is considered to be a landmark study in political economy using historical method (Wasko 2004). Through this early study, Guback highlights the importance of economic structures and practices within each film producing country which eventually help us understand how films from some countries achieve prominence globally. Wasko (2004) presents a detailed history of the research done using the political economy approach emphasising the industrial and commercial nature of the mass media. Garnham, Mattelart and Smythe's early contributions throw insight into *audiences* who were referred as the main commodity sold by media companies. Smythe's insight is of particular relevance to us as we immerse ourselves more and more into a digital world where our every keystroke on our phones and computers constitutes a data point that when collated across individuals over a period of

time builds enormous sets of fine grained data collected unobtrusively which is then mined for further audience insights.

Nicholas Garnham in his 1987 paper titled *Concepts of culture: Public policy and the cultural industries*, argued that much would be gained by examining cultural production as an economic activity (rather than as a creative process undertaken by ‘artists’). According to Garnham, “the cultural sector operates as an integrated economic whole because industries and companies within it compete: 1. for a limited pool of disposable consumer income; 2. for a limited pool of advertising revenue; 3. for a limited amount of consumption time; 4 for skilled labour” (p.26). He draws attention to the economic characteristics of cultural products such as media products to show how policy decisions have an effect on the industry.

Garnham argues that media production offers economies of scale, i.e., since the marginal cost of producing another *copy* of a media product like, say a musical album, for instance, is almost negligible if you consider how expensive it is to create the musical album in the first place. Thus if it costs very little to reach each successive audience member, a producer has great incentive to take his media product to larger and larger audiences to increase his profit. This property of economies of scale drive media industries towards monopolies since media companies gain from reaching larger and larger audiences. Garnham brings to our attention the fact that “It is cultural distribution, not cultural production that is the key locus of power and profit” (p.31), i.e., in the media sector, it is distribution rather than production which earns greater revenue. As an example, Garnham points out that if we want to explain the cultural significance of television soap operas, we need to pay attention to the institutional context within which they are produced and distributed.

12.2.1 Critical Perspective of Political Economy

As opposed to the *celebratory* stance taken by *administrative* research, the political economy approach takes a *critical* stance. Meehan (1999) lays out the distinction between the two approaches to research. She observes that “If we begin with a shared valuation that “although some problems may exist, capitalism is fundamentally good,” our research thereby takes a celebratory stance toward media products, audiences, and institutions. If our shared valuation suggests that “despite some progress, capitalism is fundamentally flawed,” a critical stance is an integral part of our research” (p. 150). Thus we see that at a very fundamental level, administrative research takes a very different perspective compared to the critical stance taken by political economy. As Meehan (1999) elaborates, “Administrative scholars celebrate ideology, commodity, and reception; our job is to deconstruct, reveal, and critique” (p. 162). As Sussman (1999) observes, “...political economy is not in the end simply an academic treatise on how organised power prevails in the allocation, production, and distribution of resources; the organisation of civil society; and the management of social equities. In its Marxian or neo-Marxian tradition, it provides an understanding for the intellectual self-defense of working people and a call to resistance and to action for the kinds of social change that put people and common welfare ahead of personal and private accumulation and privilege” (p. 85-86).

12.2.2 Characteristics of the Political Economy Approach

Despite their shared critical foundations, there have been some differences of opinion among political economy and cultural studies scholars. Political economy has been criticised since it "...refuses in practice to think about the contradictory nature of social practices" (Grossberg, 1995, p.76) and has been accused of being "too narrow, deterministic and economistic" (Wasko, 2004, p.323). On the other hand, "By focusing on consumption and reception and on the moment of interpretation, cultural studies has exaggerated the freedoms of consumption and daily life" (Garnham, 1995, p.65). However, from the positions taken by other scholars (see Morley, 1986; Gibson, 2000, cited in Parameswaran, 2004, p. 318) we find that the two approaches need not be incompatible. Cultural studies scholars have encouraged paying attention to the context within which consumption occurs, as suggested by the political economy approach. In effect, political economy helps us understand the historical, political and economic structures within which media consumption takes place and this helps us maintain a critical perspective when we explore audiences and their media consumption practices. Likewise, keeping the agency of the audiences in mind helps us when we examine the historical, political and economic structures within which media consumption takes place.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) What is Smythe's insight about the media industry?

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2) How do economies of scale arise in the media industry? What do they lead to?

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3) What are the four dimensions of the political economy approach?

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4) What are the differences between the two approaches to mass communications research?

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12.3 THE PROPAGANDA MODEL

In 1988, Edward S Herman and Noam Chomsky published the book *Manufacturing Consent- The Political Economy of the Mass Media*, which presented a model of how the American mass media functioned. They argued that "...the media serve the ends of the dominant elite" through the use of "systematic propaganda" (p.1). This model, labelled the 'Propaganda Model,' provides a framework to examine the functioning of the mass media industry.

According to Herman and Chomsky, the media use five filters to control the information that reaches audiences. The first of these filters is **ownership**. The economics of the media favour larger media companies because of the high costs involved in media production. This leads to concentration, i.e., a few large media groups dominate the market. These companies have close relationships with the government and other corporate interests, and these relationships set their news agenda.

The second filter is **advertising** which provides a source of income to news media companies and therefore plays a role in reducing the price at which the media product such as the newspaper can be sold to the reader. This also means that the advertisers' choice prevails rather than the choice of the audience. Additionally, the 'buying mood' of the audience is maintained through content that is light and non-controversial.

The third filter is in the form of the **sources** used by the news media houses. Since these companies need to follow news schedules, they use their resources such as reporters in places where they have the best chances of obtaining information, i.e., close to decision makers including bureaucrats and the police. Corporate sources are also included since along with the government sources, they are seen as official and "credible" sources. Through the provision of 'experts', press releases and other materials these sources play an important role in the news that reaches the audiences.

The fourth filter is '**flak**' or criticism including boycott by advertisers. Flak can be direct as in complaints made to media houses by those in power, or it can be indirect when it reaches the media houses through the employees and stockholders of the powerful. A number of non-profit, non-governmental organisations organised by special interests also bring pressure to bear on news media companies.

The fifth filter which provides historical context to this model is '**anticommunism**'. The elite who are property owners fear communism since it may affect their property ownership. The vagueness of the term is exploited by those in power to rally the support of the masses.

Through the presence of these five filters, news items are measured based on their 'utility' to elite interests resulting in a clear dichotomy in the way news stories are presented. 'Useful' or 'worthy' victims receive more attention and are presented differently from 'unworthy' victims. Thus we can visualise in coming news stories as passing through the five filters and collecting in two 'heaps', one consisting of coverage of 'worthy' victims which supports and benefits the status quo, and the second, consisting of coverage of 'unworthy' victims which does

not benefit the status quo. This model explains how ‘worthy’ victims receive more press coverage than ‘unworthy’ victims.

Herman and Chomsky’s model presents a clear mechanism for *how* the media function and *what* we get to see in the final media product. We can intuitively see the appeal of this model, and can apply it to the media coverage of various social issues in our own media as Herman and Chomsky have done in their book using evidence from a number of issues covered in the American media.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space below for you answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

- 1) What are the five filters in Herman and Chomsky’s propaganda model and what is their effect on news coverage?

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12.4 POLITICAL ECONOMY AND ECONOMIC POWER OF MEDIA

While scholars and journalists have begun to examine various issues related to the political economy of the media in India, much work remains to be done. The role of the government, advertising, ownership issues and the importance of the social context have featured on the research agenda. Seen in the context of the work done by international political economy scholars, these studies offer a glimpse into the complex workings of the Indian media with its multiplicity of actors such as the government, advertisers, and media company owners within the specific context of Indian society, and offer some insights into the structure and performance of the Indian media.

12.4.1 Government

Manjunath Pendakur’s (1985) work on the history of American film imports into India and the strategies used by the American film companies is an excellent illustration of McChesney and Schiller’s arguments on the importance of the role played by governments in the political economy of the media. Pendakur uses historical documents to show the support from the American government to American film distribution companies such as a willingness to intercede on their behalf with foreign governments. He records how these companies formed a cartel—the MPEAA—through which they functioned in international markets including India, which helped them to reduce operating costs and helped them to provide a united front to governments in these markets. Ironically cartels formed by American companies are illegal within America but are permitted to operate outside the USA to further American corporate interests. Pendakur (1985) remarks that, “The agendas of a U.S. cartel involved in cultural trade overseas often conflict with the national priorities and needs of Third World governments” (p.71). However since the Indian government was experiencing a shortage of foreign exchange, the expansion of American film distribution in India was restricted.

In a similar vein, McDowell (1997) focuses on the actions taken by the Indian government at the time of the arrival of satellite broadcasting in the early 1990s. He examines the history of broadcasting in India and the policy decisions which led to the creation of a national broadcasting infrastructure including the support extended to the import and assembly of television sets by private corporations. He argues that while the government retained control over the distribution of terrestrial broadcasting, but rather than produce programming it encouraged private producers to create programming which was advertiser supported. According to McDowell, “The closer relationship between the state and private capital began to form before the policy of liberalisation was introduced in the 1990s” (p. 162). This underlines McChesney and Schiller’s argument about the accord between government and corporate interests in the political economy of the media.

12.4.2 Advertising

While government and corporate interests appear to be interlinked, they are foregrounded by the direct participation of corporate interests in the media industry through advertising due to the economics of media production. In a seminar presentation P Sainath (1999), called the high dependence of Indian newspapers on advertising as the “43 paise syndrome” where newspapers were able to earn only 43 paise through the sale of each copy of the newspaper in return for Rs.6 that they spent on producing it. He points out that sales to readers are not a reliable source of income for newspapers, rather it was advertising that newspapers relied on to break even and earn profits, making advertising departments more important than editorial departments in newspapers. This reliance on advertising reveals evidence from the Indian context for the predictions of Herman and Chomsky’s propaganda model regarding the dichotomisation of news coverage when Sainath observes that the Tata small car received more coverage than starvation deaths and farmers’ suicides.

In an overlap of the influence of advertisers and the government, Robin Jeffrey focuses on the unique instances when the government is the advertiser. In his work on the Indian newspaper industry, Jeffrey (1997) notes that until the end of the 1970s, regional language newspapers were highly dependent on advertising by the government, as they were not valued by other advertisers because of the low buying power of their readers. We can speculate on the ability of these newspapers to take critical positions on policy issues given this dependence. Over the years, in addition to government and advertiser influence on the media, the ownership of the media companies has also begun to draw attention.

12.4.3 Media Ownership

In recent years, media ownership issues have begun to garner attention. Paranjy Guha Thakurtha’s (2012) work on the ownership of media companies in India reveals that companies that own media interests also have interests in other sectors of the economy. For instance, Thakurtha points out that, “...the Dainik Bhaskar group, which, in 1958, ran a single edition Hindi newspaper from Bhopal, has a market capitalisation of Rs 4,454 crore (as on July 30. 2010), owns seven newspapers, two magazines, 17 radio stations, and has a significant presence in the printing, textiles, oils, solvent extraction, hotels, real estate, and power-generation industries” (p.6). Further, he notes that Board members of media

companies also serve on Boards of companies in other sectors including retail, real estate and private equity investments.

Thakurtha's also highlights the ownership of media entities by political parties. As he points out, "In states like Kerala, West Bengal and Tamil Nadu, the political affiliation of large sections of the media are clear. One should not expect the Communist Party of India-Marxist (CPI-M) to be criticised in the pages of the *Deshabhimani* or *Ganashakti*, or J. Jayalalitha to be taken to task on *Jaya TV* or *Sun TV* to be critical of M Karunanidhi. In West Bengal and Kerala, the biggest media organisations, the *Ananda Bazar Patrika* and the *Malayala Manorama* groups respectively, are editorially opposed to the ruling regimes, while in Tamil Nadu important participants in the incumbent government are themselves promoters and controllers of large media organisations."

If corporate and political party interests are represented at the highest levels of media companies, through ownership or through the presence of board members with other interests, we need to question how these interests will act as a filter for news and other types of coverage on these media channels and most importantly, what this will mean for democracy in India. Research in this area is still in its early stages and given India's diverse media industry, is the need of the hour.

12.4.4 Social and Economic Context

In addition to the role of the government, advertisers and media owners, the economic and social context, or structural factors also play a role in the political economy of the media. Chitrapu (2013) highlights the importance of context on the advantages of combining the political economy perspective with ethnographic work when she analyses two contradictory portrayals of film fans in the mass communication research literature. She compares Meehan's (2000) examination of the *negative* portrayal of *Star Trek* fans in the American media, to Srinivas's (1996) study on the *positive* portrayal of Chiranjeevi's Telugu film fans. Meehan attributes the negative portrayal to the fans' low importance relative to the total audience as well as media companies' fear of acknowledging the deep effects of media on audiences as this might attract regulators.

Srinivas on the other hand observes the relative importance of fans to the film industry at a time of high taxation in cinema theatres. In both cases we find that the portrayal of a group of persons by the media industry depends on their relative economic importance or lack of importance to the media industry. In other words, we see the role played by the social and economic context in the representation of groups of people.

One of the most important features of Indian society is the extreme diversity in languages spoken by Indians. Unlike other countries which consist of homogenous linguistic blocks, India contains populations that speak many different languages. Further, deep bonds are observed to exist between people and their language. This plays role in the political economy of the media industry. As Jeffrey (1997) notes, "Everywhere in India the message is the same: new readers want to read about themselves; increasing circulation depends on expanding local coverage; newspapers must give their readers the latest, local news in language that they understand and enjoy. Newspapers that fail to do so will lose circulation and therefore have no hope of attracting advertisements" (p. 74).

We also see this preference for one's own language in the film and television industries. In her empirical work Chitrapu's (2012) reveals that the size of the language group and their aggregate income begins to assume significance, since larger language groups offer more lucrative markets to advertisers and media companies, leading to greater, more lavish productions in these languages as in the case of Indian language films. This is in line with predictions by media economics researchers such as Waterman (1988), Wildman and Siwek (1988) and Hoskins and Mirus (1988).

12.4.5 Paid News

Any discussion of the political economy of Indian media is incomplete without addressing the phenomenon of 'paid news' which was brought to light through the work of P Sainath and Paranjoy Guha Thakurtha during the 2009 elections. News outlets including newspapers and television news channels were found to have offered 'packages' of positive coverage to political candidates contesting elections. Candidates who were unable to afford this kind of 'coverage' received no coverage at all. As Sainath (2009) points out, "In many cases, a candidate just had to pay for almost any coverage irrespective of issue. No money, no news was the mantra of the press. It has taken the involvement of the Election Commission, the Press Council of India, the Securities and Exchange Board of India as well as attention from journalists to highlight this practice and attempts to stop it. Thakurtha notes, in states such as Tamil Nadu and Kerala where political parties own news outlets and give positive coverage to their party politicians, the audience is not faced with deception, audience members are aware of the source and the nature of the communication. However, when news media outlets publish "paid news" it is essentially advertising masquerading as news and the audience is deceived, thereby lowering the credibility of that news organisation.

12.5 PUBLIC INTEREST VS BUSINESS INTEREST

Robert McChesney and Dan Schiller (2003) argue, the media have great "democracy enhancing potential" because of their power to inform and shape public opinion besides media offer immense opportunities for earning profits. They observe that corporations and governments have been the main entities in the media industry. They dismiss the notion of the 'free press' as a myth and highlight the importance of the government in the creation of the media through spectrum licensing, support for infrastructure, innovation and copyright protection and draw our attention to the important political economy. "Private, corporate media and governments are far better seen as partners, and both far more adept at serving those who sit atop the social pyramid than those who are found closer to the bottom."

McChesney and Schiller argue that corporations have benefitted from the changes in the international media industry in the last few decades. These changes in the international media have occurred not because of technological breakthroughs, but because of their profit earning potential. The democracy enhancing power of technological breakthroughs such as digital media has not been promoted as much as their potential to enhance profits. This move towards neoliberalism has promoted the formation of large media companies and the concentration of power in the hands of a few who eventually dominate decision making. McChesney and Schiller argue that neither corporations nor governments fully utilise the

democracy enhancing potential of the media. This can only be done by the third alternative, i.e., citizen-led community media which is driven by development and democratic ideals rather than by profit or by power.

Check Your Progress 3

Note: 1) Use the space below for you answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) What are the dangers of 'paid news'?

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2) What causes the 'vital tension' in society according to McChesney and Schiller?

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12.6 CULTURAL IMPERIALISM

Early empirical studies of television programmes worldwide such as those conducted by Varis (1974) found evidence of a "one-way flow" of television programmes from the former imperial powers such as Britain and France to their former colonies in Asia and Africa with very little counter flows in the opposite direction. This was seen as evidence of cultural imperialism (Beltran 1978; Mattelart 1973; Schiller 1969) and the eventual destruction of native cultures emerged as a fear. With respect to the media specifically, a term known as 'media imperialism' was used, "...to describe the processes by which modern communication media have operated to create, maintain and expand systems of domination and dependence on a world scale" (Fejes, 1981).

However, economic correlations also emerged, countries with greater populations and larger economies were origins of these flows (Nordenstreng and Varis 1974; Varis 1985). Flows were also observed within regions, with sources and destination countries that were not former imperial powers but where the economics supported media industries (Varis 1985). Later models of media trade such as the 'home market model' effectively explained the economics of these flows.

Check Your Progress 3

Note: 1) Use the space below for you answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) What is the 'one way flow' of media?

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2) What is the main concern raised by it?

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12.7 LET US SUM UP

In this unit you learned that political economy is a critical approach that examines the history, social totality, moral philosophy and praxis of communication that can complement cultural studies. You were acquainted with the history of political economy research including Smythe's insight about audiences being the commodity that is sold to advertisers by media organisations. Garnham's work on the economies of scale in the media industry was discussed to explain the tendency towards monopoly that exists in the media industry.

Herman and Chomsky's propaganda model revealed how the five filters of ownership, advertising, sources, flak, and anticommunism lead to the dichotomisation of news, with news that benefits the elites receiving more coverage than news that does not benefit elites. Through the work of McChesney and Schiller, you were exposed to the 'vital tension', i.e., the conflict that arises from the democracy-enhancing potential pitted against the profit-earning potential of mass communications media. You also learned how changes in the international media came about not through the march of technology as is normally suggested but through their ability to benefit the existing elites.

In the unit the role played by governments was explained - as seen in the work of Pendakur on the American film distribution cartel in India and the work of McDowell on the media policy decisions that preceded liberalisation in India. The pressures brought by advertising through the work of Sainath and Jeffrey were also discussed. You also learned about the issues that arise due to the ownership of media organisations by corporations with interests in a variety of industrial sectors. Another contextual issue of unique importance in India is the size of linguistic markets and the effect it has on media products such as films. The phenomenon of 'paid news', i.e., political coverage in exchange for financial remuneration and the danger it represents to democracy was discussed.

A discussion of the political economy of the media in India reveals the value of McChesney and Schiller's suggestion that we understand the importance of citizen-led community media that is driven by development and democratic ideals to fully utilise the democracy enhancing potential of the media.

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12.9 KEY TERMS

Cartel – A group of sellers of a product who agree to fix prices, this reduces competition

Economies of scale – Seen in goods like media products, the average cost of production decreases in the long run as the output increases

Monopoly – Domination of the market by a single firm which is able to decide the price at which it wants to sell its product.

12.10 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

- 1) Smythe's (1977) insight that the main commodity sold by media companies was *audiences*, and these were sold by media companies to advertisers.
- 2) Media production offers economies of scale, and if it costs very little to reach each successive audience member, a producer has great incentive to take his media product to larger audiences to increase his profit. This property of economies of scale drives media industries towards monopolies.
- 3) The four dimensions of the political economy approach are history, social totality, moral philosophy and praxis.
- 4) The two approaches to mass communication are the administrative or celebratory approach and the critical approach. The celebratory approach accepts capitalism while the critical approach holds capitalism as fundamentally flawed.

Check Your Progress 2

- 1) The five filters in Herman and Chomsky's propaganda model are ownership, advertising, sources, flak and anticommunism. The presence of these five filters leads to the dichotomisation of news, with news that benefits the elites receiving more coverage than news that does not benefit elites.

Check Your Progress 3

- 1) When news media outlets publish 'paid news' it is essentially advertising, masquerading as news and the audience is deceived, thereby lowering the credibility of that news organisation.
- 2) According to McChesney and Schillet, "The dual life of the communication system, at once a pivot of the emerging global economy and a key

foundation of political democracy, constitutes a vital tension on the world stage”

Check Your Progress 4

- 1) The flow of media products like television programmes from former imperial powers such as Britain and France to their former colonies without a significant corresponding flow in the opposite direction was discovered in the 1970s and termed the ‘one-way’ flow.
- 2) It raised fears of media imperialism, a form of cultural imperialism in which the cultures of the receiving countries are overtaken by the culture of the imperialistic countries as well as continue the unequal relationships between imperialistic countries and their former colonies.



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